BENGALURU - MONDAY - JULY 27, 2026

₹10 • Pages 10 • Volume 4 • Number 207

www.businessline.in

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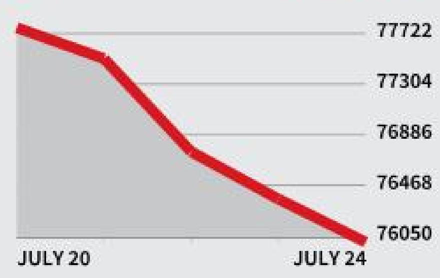

IN FOCUS

	Week's close	Week's change
Nifty 50	23767.45	-566.85
P/E Ratio (Sensex)	20.48	-0.70
US Dollar (in ₹)	96.56	+0.28
Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹)	143205.00	+2611
Silver 1 kg (in ₹)	222721.00	+7247

QUANTUM.

Tata Steel explores pathway to reducing coke usage while retaining existing steel-making infrastructure **p7**

PULSE.

RG Kar and beyond: Hospital safety remains unfinished agenda **p9**

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RNI No. KARENG/2023/85271

Nilekani to head task force on NTA reforms: PM

Ankita Upadhyay
New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday announced the constitution of a high-power task force headed by technology expert Nandan Nilekani to recommend reforms for the National Testing Agency (NTA), with a focus on overhauling the examination system through technology and structural changes.

The announcement comes amid sustained scrutiny of the NTA following a series of controversies over competitive examinations in recent years.

In a message on social media platform X, the PM said: "Friends, for the future of the students, the Indian government is taking many steps continuously. The people who played with the future of the students, they are rotting in the jails. We have already made a fast track court. We have to make sure that our exam procedures are transparent. With all these things in mind, under the leadership of the world-famous technology expert Nandan Nilekani, we have decided to form a high-power task force which will focus on examination reform."

Details p10

Inflation remains RBI's foremost priority: Governor

FOREX BOOST. Steps to attract foreign capital led to $32 b inflows, largely via FCNR(B)

bl. exclusive

Raghuvir Srinivasan
K Ram Kumar
Mahesh Ravidas Nayak
Mumbai


UMESH GOSWAMI

Reserve Bank of India Governor Sanjay Malhotra has said that inflation control remains the RBI's foremost priority even as it remains mindful of growth risks.

He said the Monetary Policy Committee (MPC) would continue to adopt a data-dependent approach while navigating the evolving growth-inflation trade-off.

"Our primary mandate is inflation and price stability. Therefore, we will do whatever is required first to keep price stability and then, to see to what extent we can support growth," he said in an interview with *businessline* on Sunday.

While inflation has moved above the 4 per cent threshold, Malhotra indicated that policymakers do not yet see signs of broad-based price pressures becoming entrenched.

FCNR(B) BOOST

Meanwhile, the RBI's recent measures to attract foreign capital have garnered strong investor response, with banks mobilising nearly $32 billion, largely through FCNR(B) deposits, while government securities have attracted more than $7 billion in foreign inflows since the June policy measures, Malhotra said.

The Governor dismissed concerns that the inflows could represent a recycling of existing deposits. He added that the RBI had adequate tools to manage any resulting liquidity.

The Governor said the measures should be viewed in the context of challenging global conditions facing emerging markets and are expected to further strengthen India's balance of payments and currency stability.

RUPEE UNDERVALUED

Malhotra also sought to reassure markets on the rupee, arguing that recent depreciation does not reflect any weakness in the country's economic fundamentals. According to him, pressure on the currency has largely stemmed from geopolitical tensions, dollar strength and broader volatility across emerging markets.

"I would like to reiterate that it would be reasonable to think that the rupee is not overvalued. If anything, one could argue that the rupee has become undervalued both in nominal and in REER (real effective exchange rate) terms," he said, adding that the RBI does not target any specific exchange rate or band for the rupee.

"Our intervention, whenever necessary, is targeted to curb excessive volatility," he said.

He pointed to a current account surplus during April-May, robust services exports, resilient remittance inflows, rising merchandise exports and improving foreign direct investment flows as indicators of external sector strength.

Responding to concerns over the RBI bearing the hedging cost of fresh FCNR (B) deposits and offering concessional forex swaps for external commercial borrowings (ECBs) by public sector entities, Malhotra said: "It is not something which should be a matter of concern because we have a foolproof system of insuring ourselves. So, whatever dollars we get, the excess foreign currency is invested in foreign assets. The risk, therefore, is not there."

Interview p3

Centre scraps ₹10,000-crore ATF fund after airlines skip MoU deadline

Rohit Vaid
New Delhi

GROUNDED. No domestic carrier signed the mandatory agreements with the OMCs within the prescribed timeframe

The Centre has discontinued its ₹10,000-crore aviation turbine fuel (ATF) Price Stabilisation Fund (PSF) scheme after no domestic airline came forward to sign the mandatory memorandum of understanding (MoU) with state-owned oil marketing companies within the prescribed timeframe, sources told *businessline*.

According to sources, the voluntary mechanism failed to take off despite the Centre operationalising the framework following the recent West Asia crisis.

"The scheme has been discontinued as no airline signed the required MoU with the OMCs within the prescribed timeline," a person aware of the development said.

In June, the Cabinet approved the one-time ₹10,000 crore PSF to protect airlines from sharp volatility in global ATF prices triggered by the West Asia tensions.

INDUSTRY SUPPORT

The scheme was designed to compensate OMCs for losses arising from supplying jet fuel to participating airlines at a pre-determined benchmark price. Under the framework, participation by airlines was voluntary. Carriers choosing to opt in were required to execute a tripartite MoU with the Ministry of Civil Aviation, the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas, and the concerned OMC before purchasing ATF under the fixed-price mechanism.

The benchmark ATF prices under the scheme were fixed at the free-on-board (FOB) level at ₹86.32 per litre for domestic operations and ₹104.49 per litre for international operations, with the effective selling price in Delhi working out to around ₹115 per litre after the applicable charges.

However, sources said the subsequent moderation in international crude oil and ATF prices significantly reduced the commercial attractiveness of the fixed-price mechanism.

As market-linked ATF prices eased following the de-escalation of tensions in West Asia, airlines preferred to continue procuring fuel under the prevailing pricing mechanism rather than commit to the stabilisation framework.

WAR IMPACT

The PSF mechanism had replaced the temporary cap on domestic ATF prices that the government introduced after international jet fuel prices surged sharply during the height of the West Asia crisis.

Per sources, while the present scheme has been discontinued, the government remains prepared to consider similar market-stabilisation measures should global fuel prices witness another prolonged period of exceptional volatility.

"The framework was created to address an extraordinary situation. If similar circumstances arise again, the government has the experience and policy framework to respond quickly," sources said.

Small truckers face a survival crisis amid rising costs and weak freight rates

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

Rising diesel prices, toll, insurance, loan repayments and maintenance costs leave little room for profit

Ludhiana-based Roshan Singh Chawla, 52, owns three trucks — two Tata Prima heavy-duty trucks and an Ashok Leyland BOSS, which he purchased last Diwali. Trucking has supported his family for over two decades. But his sons have no plans to carry it forward.

Ritesh is in the final year of his BCom degree, while Arjun has just completed Class 12. Neither sees a future in the family transport business.

COST BURDEN

Finding drivers has become a struggle. When one fails to report, Chawla takes the wheel. Rising diesel prices, toll, insurance, loan repayments, maintenance and compliance costs leave little room for profit. "We are only seeking a fair, viable and sustainable business environment," Chawla said.

His predicament reflects a crisis among India's transport operators. The All India Motor Transport Congress (AIMTC) said owner-drivers and micro-fleet operators, who move 70 per cent of domestic freight, are being squeezed by rising costs, stagnant freight rates, expensive finance and limited pricing power.

"If immediate corrective measures are not taken, thousands of small transport operators and self-driving truck owners will be forced to shut down, severely impacting India's supply chain and economy," said Bal Malkit Singh, adviser and former AIMTC President.

For decades, owning a truck offered a dependable livelihood. Today, diesel accounts for 55-60 per cent of operating costs, according to AIMTC, while toll, tyres, insurance, AdBlue, lubricants, maintenance, permits and compliance have all become more expensive.

More than three-fourths of India's transport operators own five or fewer trucks, industry estimates suggest. Dependent on brokers and freight platforms, many accept low-paying loads to keep vehicles moving and to service loans.

SHORTAGE OF DRIVERS

The industry faces a shortage of 2.2 million commercial vehicle drivers. Long periods away from home, poor roadside amenities, unsafe parking and weak returns are discouraging younger workers. For owner-operators, the shortage means longer hours behind the wheel.

AIMTC has sought a review of mandatory vehicle-location tracking devices, citing installation costs and glitches in Vahan integration that delay fitness certificate renewals and permit approvals. It has urged the Centre and the States to rationalise toll, simplify compliance, improve highway facilities and link freight rates to operating costs.

Bhogapuram airport set to take flight on tribal beats

13,000 artistes from the Araku region to perform at the airport opening on August 1

G Naga Sridhar
Hyderabad

Locals from tribal communities performing the Dhimsa dance in Bosubeda, near Araku Valley KR DEEPAK

When the new Alluri Sitarama Raju International Airport opens at Bhogapuram, near Visakhapatnam, it will not just launch flights — it will also bring to the fore the rhythms of Andhra Pradesh's indigenous culture.

Before the first commercial flight takes off, the tarmac will vibrate to the synchronised steps of 13,000 tribal dancers performing the ancient Dhimsa dance.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi will formally inaugurate the greenfield airport, developed by the GMR Group, on August 1. He will also address a public meeting after the inauguration.

According to Andhra Pradesh Minister Kondapalli Srinivas, commercial operations at the airport will commence on August 17. It is not just the inaugural festivities; the airport's name also strikes an emotional chord with the locals.

Alluri Sitarama Raju was a celebrated revolutionary who united the tribal communities of the Manyam region and led the heroic 'Rampa Rebellion' against British colonial rule, eventually laying down his life for the cause.

According to an Andhra Pradesh Tourism Department official, Dhimsa is the best-known cultural expression of the hill tribes of the Araku Valley. Typically performed by groups of 15- 20 women dressed in colourful traditional sarees and ornaments, the dance features synchronised movements set to the rhythm of indigenous instruments played by male members of the community. These include the Mori, a wind instrument, and the Thudum and Dappu drums.

The synchronised movements reflect communal unity, friendship and the deep bond between tribal communities and nature, while the dance's various forms portray worship, hunting, agriculture and everyday life.

Nearly 3 lakh people from Visakhapatnam, Vizianagaram, Srikakulam, Anakapalli and Parvathipuram Manyam districts are expected to attend the event. Around 5,000 buses will transport participants from 36 Assembly constituencies to the venue.

LED SCREENS

MT Krishna Babu, Chief Officer of the Airport Inauguration Committee, said an LED screen would be installed for every 5,000 attendees to enable the audience to watch the Prime Minister's address.

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QUICKLY.

Work for commoners' benefit, FM tells I-T dept

Mumbai: Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman urged the Income Tax department to work for the benefit of the common people. She expressed disappointment at the laidback nature of government departments, which leads to illegal occupation or encroachments on government lands. Citing the challenges faced by the department in getting a nod to construct a building in Nariman Point, Sitharaman said these experiences, despite serving in the Indian Revenue Service, would have given them an idea of what the common man goes through. PTI

TN extends State Finance Commission's tenure

Chennai: The Tamil Nadu government, by way of a gazette notification, has extended the tenure of the Seventh State Finance Commission by four months, until December 31, 2026. The Commission is tasked with examining the financial position of various urban and rural local bodies and making appropriate recommendations to the State government. Its tenure was originally scheduled to expire on August 31, 2026. The Seventh State Finance Commission is chaired by the retired IAS officer K Allaudin, and was formed in May 2025. OUR BUREAU

Russian supply disruption poses fresh risk to India's crude imports

RISING UNCERTAINTY. Ukrainian attacks on key export infrastructure could inflate freight costs

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

Crude oil imports in August face a fresh risk from Russia, with uncertainty mounting over crude loadings from the Black Sea port of Novorossiysk following Ukrainian attacks on key export infrastructure. The volume of imports during the month will also depend on the safe passage of Saudi Arabian barrels through the Bab el-Mandeb (BeM) strait.

While refiners and traders do not expect an outright supply disruption, they warn that slower deliveries, higher freight costs and shrinking discounts on Russian crude could inflate India's oil import bill, particularly at a time when the rupee remains weak against the US dollar.

Russia has emerged as India's largest crude supplier over the past three years, accounting for as much as 50 per cent of the country's imports as refiners increasingly rely on discounted Urals crude because of the Western sanctions.

STRATEGIC RELIANCE. Russia has emerged as India's largest crude supplier over the past three years, accounting for as much as 50 per cent of the country's imports REUTERS

Any disruption to these supplies, therefore, carries outsized implications for Indian refiners, many of whom have reconfigured their sourcing around Russian barrels.

"As we speak, there are two developing scenarios important to track. First, crude oil (Urals grade) loadings from Novorossiysk port, considering the attacks by Ukraine on the Sheskharis terminal. Besides, traders are not offering discounts for September loadings. So, barrels will be there, but there will be a price," said a trade source.

KEY UNCERTAINTY

According to Kpler, the key uncertainty is whether Russia can sustain export volumes amid continued Ukrainian attacks on its upstream and downstream infrastructure.

Russia's crude exports in July declined by around 4,00,000 barrels per day month-on-month.

Sheskharis, Russia's largest crude export terminal, accounts for nearly 20 per cent of its seaborne crude shipments.

The concern for India is less about physical availability than pricing. If Russian exporters trim discounts or shipments, Indian refiners will either have to pay more for Russian crude or replace some of those barrels with costlier cargoes from other suppliers, pushing up procurement costs and the country's import bill.

The second variable is the continuing threat by Houthi rebels to Saudi Arabian crude exports transiting the Bab el-Mandeb strait.

"The threat has already impacted supply from there. Although the Saudis are using Egypt's Sidi Kerir terminal on the Mediterranean coast, it also increases costs," the same source said.

ALTERNATIVE ROUTES

According to Equirus Securities, tankers can avoid the Bab el-Mandeb by taking alternative routes through the Suez Canal and the Mediterranean, but doing so could add nearly a month to voyage times.

Longer journeys keep vessels tied up for extended periods, reduce tanker availability and significantly raise freight and insurance costs. Freight and insurance charges, which averaged $4-5 per barrel before the conflict, have now climbed to $13-15 per barrel.

An official with a domestic refiner said the expectation is that both Russian and Saudi barrels will continue to be available, but the logistics are becoming increasingly "tricky". "Saudi Arabia usually supplies crude through VLCCs, but bypassing the traditional Red Sea route and exporting via Sidi Kerir adds to both voyage time and transportation costs," the official said.

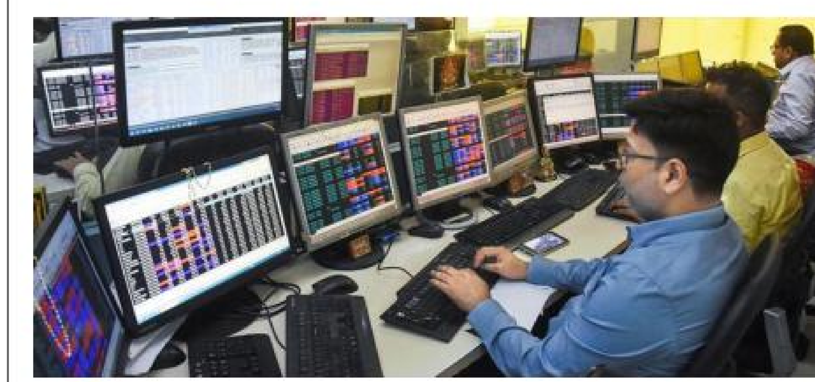
Geopolitical tensions have already begun influencing global oil prices.

According to S&P Global Commodity Insights, mounting concerns over disruptions to Red Sea shipping helped push Brent crude futures above $100 per barrel on July 23.

Kpler said that if Red Sea transit remains uninterrupted, Indian refiners will continue to have an important supply buffer through Saudi Arabia's East-West pipeline to Yanbu, which recently supplied around 3,00,000-5,00,000 barrels per day of crude.

"However, if the security situation deteriorates and Red Sea imports become unavailable during August, refiners will need to replace those barrels from alternative sources," it said.

Amid slower growth trends, MTF book reaches ₹1.43 lakh cr



SHARP GROWTH. CareEdge said the MTF book had grown 11.1% in May from April, after a 1.6% rise in April ANI

Akshata Gorde
Mumbai

The industry's margin trading facility (MTF) book touched a fresh high of ₹1,43,722 crore on July 22, as investor appetite for leveraged cash-market positions remains strong even as the pace of growth has slowed from earlier months.

The latest figure was led by the NSE at ₹1,37,705 crore, while the BSE's MTF book stood at ₹6,017 crore. In June, the industry ended with a record average MTF book of ₹1.36 lakh crore, up 7.1 per cent sequentially and 57.6 per cent year-on-year.

The pace of growth slowed slightly to 5.1 per cent in July. CareEdge said the book had grown 11.1 per cent in May from April, after a 1.6 per cent rise in April.

AVERAGE TURNOVER

Average daily turnover across equity and derivatives remained largely flat sequentially in June after a sharp run-up earlier this year, with higher securities transaction tax (STT) on derivatives, easing market volatility and cautious investor sentiment weighing on activity. The cash market turnover also softened after three consecutive months of growth, said CareEdge Ratings.

"The MTF book crossing ₹1.4 lakh crore itself indicates that investor appetite remains strong. The moderation in growth during July is not a concern; after a sharp run-up over the last few months, some cooling was always expected," Ajay Garg, Director and CEO at SMC Global Securities said. "Investors are becoming more selective as valuations turn richer and markets witness intermittent volatility, which is a healthy sign rather than a negative one," he said.

ROOM TO GROW

The segment still has room to grow as retail participation in markets deepens. "MTF has emerged as a useful financing tool for informed investors. We expect growth to continue, although at a more sustainable pace than what we have seen recently," Garg said.

Shripal Shah, MD & CEO at Kotak Securities, said the industry's MTF book rise shows growing investor preference for regulated leverage through the cash market.

"As activity in derivatives has moderated due to higher trading costs and regulatory changes, MTF has emerged as an attractive alternative for investors seeking leveraged exposure," he said. Further, the wider availability of MTF on digital platforms has supported adoption.

He also said the RBI's revised funding norms for capital market intermediaries are aimed at funding structures and proprietary trading rather than retail participation.

The long-term growth outlook for MTF remains intact due to rising investor adoption and its growing importance in brokers' business models.

EPFO traces 1.18 lakh dormant accounts holding less than ₹1,000 for auto-refund

Dalip Singh
New Delhi

The Ministry of Labour and Employment has traced 1.18 lakh of the 7.11 lakh inactive Employees' Provident Fund Organisation (EPFO) account holders eligible for automatic refunds of balances up to ₹1,000 lying unclaimed for years or even decades.

Ministry sources told *businessline* that the EPFO has been able to authenticate 1.18 lakh subscribers' individual account data with their active bank details. They described it as part of a pro-people step which began in 2014 when the Modi government came to power and introduced the scheme of providing a unique 12-digit account number for an EPFO subscriber, called Universal Account Number (UAN).

The Centre for Development of Advanced Computing (C-DAC), a Ministry of Electronics and Information

Technology (MeitY) research and development entity working on the complex backhand tasks, has been tasked to upgrade and migrate the software for auto credit of provident fund amounts due to each of them in their respective bank accounts.

DORMANT ACCOUNTS

Overall ₹30.52 crore has been lying idle in 7.11 lakh inoperative EPF accounts holding ₹1,000 or less. The account holders are not required to submit any application for receiving their legitimate due PF money with interest, Ministry sources stressed.

Among the painstaking layered efforts as part of the EPFO 2.01 reform, the organisation kick-started the "penny drop" into Aadhar-linked inoperative accounts. After that, the officials collected details of the respective bank accounts from the banks. From that exercise, the EPFO managed to sort out names of account holders who are dead.

The EPFO, according to Ministry sources, has been able to extract data, but the enabling software change is still to happen.

"Now, individual data has to be inserted into respective the EPFO account holder's profile. This is just one aspect of the software drive in the national database creation drive. Another process integration underway is that the existing system is only tuned to respond to 'claims' by EPFO members but in this case, no such thing exists. For that adjustment, the C-DAC has been authorised to create a 'system generated claim' facility," Ministry sources explained.

The entire process, which began on February 23, 2026, when Minister for Labour and Employment Mansukh Mandaviya gave a nod for a pilot project to auto credit EPF money into 7.11 lakh inoperative accounts, each having a balance of ₹1,000 or less, is expected to get ready by August-end for auto refund.

Once the project is successful, the Ministry wants to similarly return the money of remaining 24.76 lakh subscribers, who have more than ₹1,000 in their accounts, *businessline* had reported earlier.

The digital transformation will take away physical intervention, which otherwise workers had to make to get back their own money that was due to them. This was the reason for rolling out the pilot project, said Ministry sources.

As per the Ministry's estimate, ₹10,903 crore is lying idle in 31.86 lakh unclaimed accounts, opened over the last two decades.

No mention of NEET protests in *Mann Ki Baat*

Our Bureau
New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday used his monthly *Mann Ki Baat* broadcast to spotlight India's growing defence capabilities, space achievements, environmental conservation and grassroots success stories, while making no reference to the protests at Delhi's Jantar Mantar or the controversy surrounding the NEET-UG paper leak.

In an address coinciding with Kargil Vijay Diwas, Modi paid tribute to soldiers who fought in the 1999 Kargil War and said the country was honouring their sacrifice by building a stronger and more self-reliant defence ecosystem. He mentioned about the indigenously built missile system and said India's defence exports and strategic partnerships are steadily expanding.

"Whether it is defence production, defence exports or political cooperation with friendly nations — India is continuously scaling new heights. Earlier this month, I was in Indonesia, where a major agreement regarding BrahMos and Astra missiles was concluded," said the PM.

ENVIRONMENT & SPACE

He also focused on water conservation through the 'Catch the Rain' campaign, urging the people to participate in restoring ponds, wells and other traditional water bodies.

On science and technology, Modi hailed the successful launch of Vikram-1, describing it as India's first privately developed rocket and evidence of the gains from opening the space sector to private players.

He also congratulated Indian students for their medal-winning performances at the international science Olympiads.

Modi urged citizens to install eco-friendly clay idols during the upcoming Ganesh festival, and paid tribute to former President APJ Abdul Kalam ahead of his death anniversary.

Won't contest 2028 polls, says Karnataka ex-CM Siddaramaiah

Press Trust of India
Bengaluru

Former Karnataka Chief Minister Siddaramaiah on Sunday announced that he will not contest the 2028 Assembly polls, citing advancing age and politics becoming "deeply polluted".

The Congress Working Committee member, however, asserted that he will remain active in politics.

"Politics has become deeply polluted today, and for that reason I will not contest the 2028 Assembly elections. However, I will remain active in politics and continue to be a voice for the people's hardships and well-being," Siddaramaiah said in a post on 'X', detailing what he said at a private event held on Saturday at KR Pet in Mandya district. Noting that the people of the Varuna constituency are urging him to contest the elections again, he said, "I have decided that I should not contest any more elections. Earlier, when I contested elections, it was the people of the constituency who supported us financially and ensured our victory. Today, that situation no longer exists."

"I am now 79-years-old. Our (Congress) government's term has another year and a half remaining. By then, I will be 81-82 years old. I may not be able to work with the same energy and enthusiasm as before," he said.

T+0 settlement rollout remains in limbo as brokers struggle with readiness

Suresh P Iyengar
Mumbai

The much-anticipated T+0 settlement proposal seems to have been put on the backburner after receiving three consecutive extensions amid resistance from brokers.

Leading stock exchanges NSE and BSE launched the beta version of the T+0 settlement cycle in March 2024, even as the stock markets were operating on a T+1 settlement cycle. Subsequently, SEBI increased the number of scrips eligible for trading under the optional T+0 settlement cycle from 25 to the top 500 stocks by market capitalisation.

SEBI DEADLINE

However, brokers were not ready with the required systems to allow investors to trade under the T+0 settlement cycle because same-day settlement not only reduces their float income but also increases technology-related expenditure. The T+0 settlement cycle refers to a mechanism wherein the shares and money are credited to buyers and sellers on the day of the trade.

Initially, SEBI set the deadline for rolling out the T+0 settlement cycle as May 1, 2025, and extended it to November 1, 2025, before postponing it indefinitely.

Last October, SEBI, in a circular, said, "Considering the challenges highlighted by qualified stock brokers in ensuring the timely readiness of systems... it has been decided to extend the timeline and the revised timeline will be communicated at a later date."

LONG-TERM INVESTORS

Rajesh Singla, CEO and Fund Manager, Alpha AMC, said, "T+0 is a genuinely good idea, but brokers face multiple challenges, including running T+0 and T+1 settlements simultaneously for the same securities under the same ISIN. It creates operational complexity since most brokers simply have not built the back-end infrastructure required to handle this." Broker infrastructure needs to be upgraded with SEBI support, potentially through incentives or mandatory implementation timelines, said Singla.

Anand James, Chief Market Strategist, Geojit Investments, said a buyer in a T+0 transaction may not share the same enthusiasm as the seller in arranging funds on the same day, especially when T+1 is already running. Presently, there is hardly visible incentive to move towards T+0, especially for long-term investors.

TODAY'S PICK.

KIMS (₹797.25): BUY

Akhil Nallamuthu
bl. research bureau

The stock of KIMS (Krishna Institute of Medical Sciences) has been in a long-term uptrend. But after hitting a record high of ₹858.15 on July 6, the price dropped.

However, the stock is now hovering near the support at ₹780 where a rising trendline coincides. Moreover, the stock has formed a morning star candlestick pattern on the daily chart. Hence, the indications are that the trend is turning bullish, and we are likely to see a fresh leg of rally from the current level. An upswing can lift the stock to ₹900.

Traders can buy now at ₹797 and place stop-loss at ₹760. When the price hits ₹850, revise the stop-loss to ₹800. On a rally to ₹875, raise the stop-loss to ₹860. Book profits at ₹900.

Note: The recommendations are based on technical analysis. There is a risk of loss in trading

‘We are committed to ensuring financial stability’

SETTING THE AGENDA. We will do whatever is required first to maintain price stability and then to see to what extent we can support growth, says RBI Governor Sanjay Malhotra

bl. exclusive

K Ram Kumar
Mahesh Ravidas Nayak
Thomas K Thomas
Raghuvir Srinivasan
Mumbai

Ahead of the upcoming Monetary Policy Committee meeting in August, Reserve Bank of India Governor Sanjay Malhotra sat down with *businessline* on Sunday for a comprehensive interview at the central bank's headquarters in Mumbai. Malhotra underlined that price stability remains the central bank's foremost priority even as it seeks to support growth as inflation risks re-emerge and global uncertainties cloud the economic outlook. He stressed that monetary policy decisions will remain data-dependent, highlighted the $32 billion mobilised through recent foreign capital measures, expressed confidence that the rupee is not overvalued, and outlined the RBI's roadmap on liquidity, CBDC adoption, banking reforms and financial stability.

Edited excerpts:

Does the current repo rate meet your objective of keeping inflation under check while supporting growth?

The present rate is the appropriate rate as assessed by the MPC in view of the prevailing growth-inflation dynamics and outlook in June 2026 amid heightened global uncertainties.

Our primary mandate is price stability. Although generalised inflation pressures continue to remain modest so far, the risk of higher food, fuel and other input prices translating to a broad-based inflation environment is real. But our team is assessing the growth-inflation dynamics. We are heading into our next Monetary Policy Committee (MPC) meeting shortly. We will take an appropriate decision based on the data available and the outlook.

Inflation has breached the mid-point of the MPC's tolerance band. Would you look through it?

The response of monetary policy to a supply shock is needed when it feels that inflation is getting generalised, or it is de-anchoring expectations. As I said, we are seeing some signs, but they are modest. Let's wait for more data and let's not pre-empt the MPC.

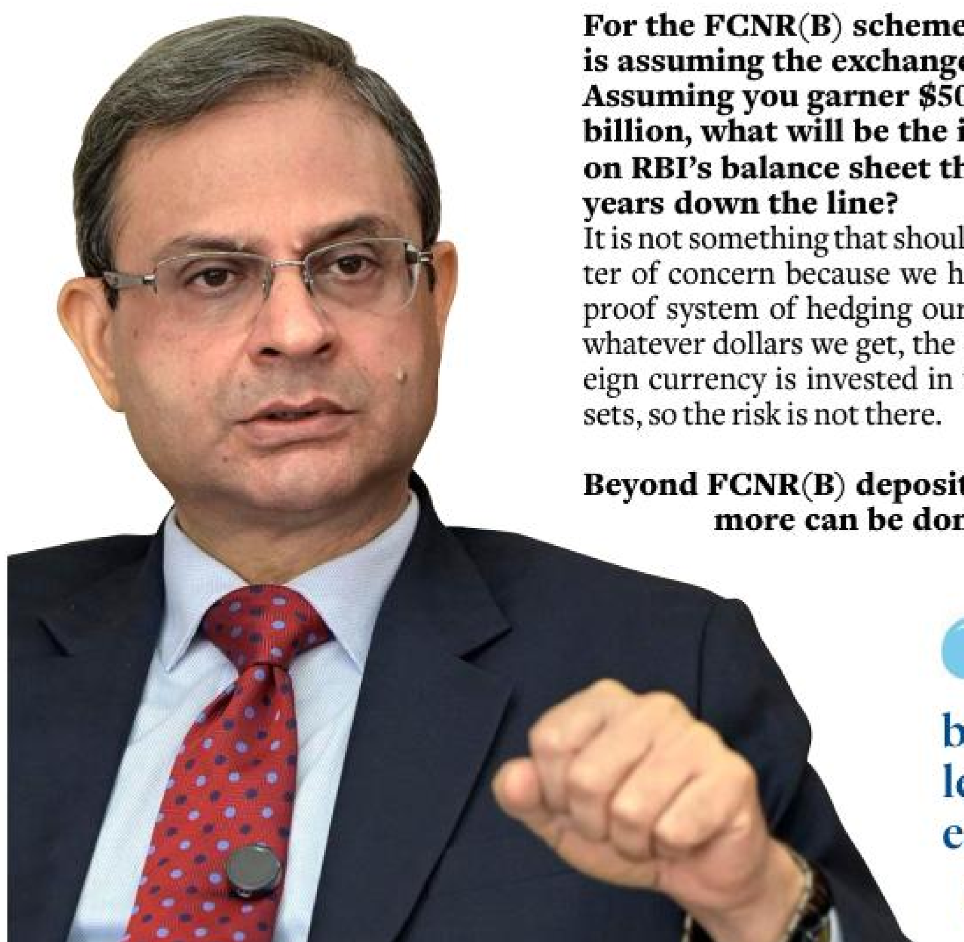
In recent times, the MPC has placed a premium on growth versus inflation. You have been helped by the fact that inflation has been benign. Now, going forward, if there is a threat to growth, what will be your approach to the growth-inflation dynamic?

First of all, I would say that our primary mandate is inflation and price stability. Even in the past period, we have been guided by that and not so much by growth. We are required to keep growth in mind while we endeavour to meet our primary objective of price stability. As you rightly mentioned, inflation was very benign and so we could continue, therefore, to support growth by reducing the policy rate by 125 basis points.

However, as I mentioned, it is price stability which is our primary mandate. Growth is certainly a consideration. Therefore, we will do whatever is required first, to maintain price stability and then, to see to what extent we can support growth.

If you increase the repo rate down the line, will it be preceded by a change in stance?

As indicated last year in my statement of April 2025, the stance of monetary policy signals the intended direction of policy rates going forward. MPC is maintaining neutral stance right now, which gives flexibility to maintain status quo, or move policy rates either way. Therefore, it may not be necessary to change stance before taking any policy action. But, of course, all decisions on policy rate and the stance will be taken by the MPC after taking cognisance of the incoming data and the domestic inflation-growth dynamics.



In the backdrop of geopolitical tensions, tariff wars and supply chain disruptions, managing the exchange rate has become even more challenging for central banks across the world. How are you treading this path where the rupee is subject to volatility due to dollar appreciation, FPI outflows and demand for the greenback from importers?

I will make four points in this regard. One, most emerging market economies and Asian currencies have been under pressure since the outbreak of the West Asia conflict for reasons well known to all. The rupee is not an outlier or an exception. In fact, it has performed better than many Asian peers.

Two, the depreciation in the rupee this year is not a reflection of India's sound economic fundamentals. It has been largely driven by the expectations channel. India's current account recorded a surplus of $2.8 billion in April-May 2026 against a deficit of $4.1 billion in the corresponding period of last year. Surplus in current account has accrued on account of strong services exports and remittances. Goods exports have also grown.

Similarly, FDI in the first two months of this financial year recorded a net inflow of around $6.5 billion against $2.5 billion in the same period last year. External commercial borrowings (ECBs) also recorded net inflows during this period.

Three, for a number of reasons, the medium-term outlook on the external sector, including BoP and forex reserves, is favourable and, therefore, we expect the real economy channel to remain positive and expectations channel to improve.

Four, regarding our policy on exchange rate, I must reiterate that it remains unchanged.

Can you share details of the inflows as a result of the measures you have undertaken to attract foreign capital inflows?

Till date, banks have mobilised almost $32 billion. Obviously, most of it is coming through FCNR (B) deposits. The figures related to ECBs and OFCBs are lumpy. In addition, we have got more than $7 billion inflows in government securities since June 5 when the policy announcements with respect to government securities were made. At this pace, the total inflows are likely to be robust.

Are your measures aimed at improving the sentiment or bolstering the forex reserves?

As I mentioned, the external real economy in terms of current account and FDI is doing reasonably well, given the circumstances where crude oil prices have gone up. It is the expectations channel that needs to be anchored to the real fundamentals of the economy. I am confident that the structural as well as capital flow related measures that have been taken by the government and the RBI should, going forward, improve the sentiment.

How much of the $32 billion is recirculation of existing deposits to take advantage of higher rates? And how much of it is fresh deposits?

We are keeping a very close watch on this. We do not find any *prima facie* evidence of recirculation of the existing deposits in whatever form to be of any significance or concern.

Why are the inflows not reflected in rupee liquidity, given that system liquidity remains under stress?

Durable liquidity has increased by about ₹1.2 lakh crore since June 5. As to why the flows are not fully reflected in system liquidity, there are two primary reasons. First, funds mobilised by banks are often swapped with the Reserve Bank, and therefore enter the system with a lag. Second, government balances have increased by roughly ₹2.9 lakh crore since June 5. These are the main reasons. Some liquidity has also been absorbed because of our market interventions.

For the FCNR(B) scheme, the RBI is assuming the exchange risk. Assuming you garner $50-60 billion, what will be the impact on RBI's balance sheet three years down the line?

It is not something that should be a matter of concern because we have a foolproof system of hedging ourselves. So, whatever dollars we get, the excess foreign currency is invested in foreign assets, so the risk is not there.

Beyond FCNR(B) deposits, what more can be done to attract foreign capital on a sustained basis?

India has taken several steps to attract foreign capital. Reforms such as 100 per cent FDI in insurance, tax concessions for data centres, expansion of the FAR (fully accessible route) framework, and higher investment limits for NRIs and OCIs have strengthened the investment climate.

While geopolitical developments may create short-term pressures, diversification of energy sources, higher ethanol blending, EV adoption and moderation in gold imports should help contain the merchandise trade deficit, while strong remittances and services exports will support the current account.

Over the medium term, sustained macroeconomic stability, financial and currency stability, policy consistency and continued structural reforms will be the key drivers of stable, long-term capital inflows. We remain committed to ensuring external sector resilience and financial stability, including currency stability. We will do whatever it takes to ensure this as financial stability is the bedrock of economic growth.

PHOTO CREDIT: UMESH GOSWAMI

> Our philosophy of forex management is driven by three considerations: safety (which should be a concern for everyone), liquidity and returns

Given the volatility in the rupee, has there been any change in the way the RBI manages it?

Our policy for exchange rate management remains unchanged. We do not target any specific rate or band for the rupee. Our intervention, whenever necessary, is targeted to curb excessive volatility in the exchange rate. And to ensure an orderly movement in the foreign exchange rates. I would also like to reiterate that it would be reasonable to think that the rupee is not overvalued. If anything, one could argue that the rupee has become undervalued, both in nominal and in REER (real effective exchange rate) terms. Once the situation in West Asia stabilises, one could very well see the rupee appreciate as one has seen during similar past periods and episodes of external shock-driven volatility.

Given the external pressures on the rupee, do you think you need to take a look at how you manage the forex reserves? Maybe diversify more?

Our philosophy of forex management is driven by three considerations: safety (which should be a concern for everyone), liquidity and returns. We periodically re-evaluate our needs, and based on that, we take decisions with respect to our forex reserve management.

Most of the trading in the government securities markets is concentrated in 10-year segment. What measures are you planning to ensure trading across the yield curve?

A number of measures have been taken over the years to provide liquidity at various points, along with the yield curve. The most important of these is the benchmark issuance strategy, which is in place for several years now for GoI securities and is now being extended to State government securities. You are aware that recently we had announced certain measures. First, the universe of specified securities under the fully accessible route was expanded. That would help.

Then there were some conditions within the general route, which have been further relaxed. These will help broaden the participation of the markets. The government had also exempted withholding tax and capital gains tax on government securities. All these measures should help broaden participation across the term structure of the government securities market.

Can you update us on the progress in CBDC implementation?

CBDC remains in the pilot phase, with around ₹40,000 crore in transactions and 1.2 crore retail users. We are focused on enhancing its features, including programmability for government direct benefit transfers and tokenisation for instruments such as certificates of deposit.

We are also exploring its use in cross-border payments through collaborations with several countries. Since the technology is still evolving, our priority is to refine and mature the platform before considering wider adoption.

Are we moving towards using CBDC for settlements between India and other countries or groups of countries?

Yes, that is also at the pilot stage. We are in discussions with a few countries. There is also a project called Nexus, initiated by the BIS Innovation Hub. However, there are many regulatory and technical developments that need to happen before such initiatives can become fully successful.

> Rather than setting timelines, our priority is to build a robust and interoperable lending infrastructure. As the ecosystem matures, ULI has the potential to become for lending what UPI is for payments

What is the progress on the unified lending interface (ULI) once spoken of as the next UPI?

ULI is currently in an ecosystem-building phase, with 129 lenders leveraging over 140 data sources for digital lending. Our focus is on onboarding more lenders and integrating additional financial and government datasets to enable seamless, end-to-end digital loan journeys and more informed credit decisions.

Rather than setting timelines, our priority is to build a robust and interoperable lending infrastructure. As the ecosystem matures, ULI has the potential to become for lending what UPI is for payments.

The last universal bank licences were issued in 2014. What is the RBI's approach to bank licensing?

The RBI's objective is to promote financial inclusion and competition while ensuring that banks are financially sound and capable of safeguarding depositors' money. Given the fiduciary nature of banking, trust, adequate capital, technology, competence and viability remain key licensing considerations.

We have an on-tap licensing framework for universal and small finance banks, along with transition routes for NBFCs, urban cooperative banks and small finance banks. We are seeing strong interest, particularly from small finance banks, in transitioning to universal banks.

You made an interesting point about trust. Are there not enough trustworthy entities available to apply for licences?

It is not only a question of trust. Applicants must also possess adequate capital, technology, competence and experience. A number of universal banks and small finance banks have already been entrusted with this responsibility, and more banks will continue to receive licences as they become eligible.

How large is the licensing pipeline currently?

As of now, to my knowledge, there is one application pending. However, there is considerable interest among small finance banks. We recently granted an in-principle licence to AU Small Finance Bank to transition into a universal bank. Interest has also been expressed by other small finance banks. Going forward, we hope that some of them will meet our criteria and graduate into full-fledged universal banks.

Some small finance banks have requested permission to co-lend with universal banks and NBFCs, particularly in areas such as gold lending, where they lack network strength. What are your thoughts?

Co-lending has been designed to ensure that the comparative strengths of both the partner institutions can be leveraged. One is expected to provide the reach while other to provide funding support.

Current scheme of things don't allow small finance banks (SFBs) to participate in co-lending. The thought process is that SFBs should first grow organically and gain adequate experience before relying extensively on leverage. It is important for them to develop expertise in banking services, including lending, within their own institutions and eventually graduate into larger entities and universal banks.

Regarding urban cooperative banks (UCBs), there has been a demand for licensing for more than 20 years. There has been no licence that the RBI has issued for obvious reasons because there were a lot of problems in the sector. Now, it seems the sector has been cleaned up to some extent. Do you think it's time for the RBI to review its licensing, and whether you'll look at consolidation first before giving fresh licences?

Licensing of UCBs was paused in 2004 against the backdrop of vulnerabilities in the sector. The expectation was for the sector to consolidate, mature and become viable.

Overall financial health of UCBs has improved since then, and the regulatory and supervisory powers of the RBI have also been augmented. The RBI had, therefore, issued a discussion paper on January 13 this year for stakeholder consultation. We are reviewing the comments received from the public and stakeholders, and we will take a view shortly.

Gold loans have seen quite a bit of run up. Is the RBI concerned about this kind of growth?

We have a very efficient and effective system of supervision, both off-site and on-site. They are vigilant and alert to any risks that may be developing in any segment or sector.

As of now, we do not find any material risk buildup. The slippage ratios and the non-performing assets in the gold loan segment are very, very low — less than about 0.2 per cent or so on average. As of now, we don't see any evidence of a major stability issue; we shall, however, continue to monitor the portfolio behaviour.

> The Monetary Policy Committee will continue to remain data-dependent, and will respond appropriately as the evolving macroeconomic outlook warrants

> We remain committed to ensuring external sector resilience. We will do whatever it takes to ensure this

Are there any concerns about governance in banks? One of the leading banks had some issues at the top...

We have a well-defined and effective regulatory regime that has been put in place based on risk for different categories of regulated entities. At the same time, we have a supervisory mechanism to ensure that those regulations are followed. Regulation is always evolving, and we recently consolidated and rationalised some pieces of the governance framework, which will guide our endeavour going forward. Where concerns arise in any regulated entity, we engage with them for initiating corrective action.

Till sometime ago, credit and deposit growth were converging. Now, it is again diverging, almost like a 400 basis points difference between credit growth and deposit growth. Is this kind of divergence a cause for concern?

I will make a few points here. One, every rupee of credit leads to an equivalent amount of deposit getting created. Two, what banks need to give credit are their own capital and enough liquidity. These are the two primary determinants of credit, and banks are well-positioned in this regard.

Three, it is, however, possible that one bank may have excess deposits and another may have lower deposits, but there is a competitive market where banks can buy and sell, which should also help ensure that stock of deposits align. The fourth aspect here is that the nature of deposits is changing from retail to money funds and corporates, and that has implications for liquidity.

Are we at the risk of overheating because credit growth is around 17 to 19 per cent? Do we see a demand-side inflation risk because credit is growing faster?

Continuing with my previous response, I would mention that the base for deposits is much more than credit, so the growth rate of credit is higher than that of deposits, but the difference in absolute terms is not so much. Banks need to maintain capital adequacy, short-term liquidity coverage ratio, and the Net Stable Funding Ratio (NSFR) for long-term periods. They should concentrate on these three while giving out credit.

There are increasing concerns around AI platforms and cybersecurity. The RBI has held meetings with banks on the issue. What has been your assessment?

AI is creating significant opportunities, but it is also changing the nature and speed of technology and cybersecurity risks. We are fully geared to meet these challenges. What these AI platforms essentially do is identify and expose existing vulnerabilities in systems much more quickly.

We shall continue to engage with our regulated entities, other financial sector regulators and the government. The RBI also has a highly competent team, C-SITE, that supervises and audits the technology platforms of major regulated entities. We provide continuous guidance and ensure that weaknesses are identified and addressed.

We remain alert to these risks and will continue strengthening our technology systems.

You were in government when the Ukraine situation hit, and now you are at the RBI heading operations during the Iran crisis and other issues. Are you becoming a specialist policymaker in war times? Personally, which has been more challenging for you: your stint at the Finance Ministry or guiding the country here at the RBI?

The last five years have been challenging. We have not seen as many crises in many decades as in the last five years.

But let me mention that we have used every such event to further our resilience, and we are confident we will come out much stronger even after this episode.

As for your question, both have been challenging, but obviously the buck stops with you here (at RBI), so to that extent, the challenges are different.

BENGALURU
businessline.
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MONDAY - JULY 27, 2026

Positive indicator

Q1 direct tax mop-up affirms growth prospects

Direct tax collections, gross and net, for the first quarter of this fiscal have turned in a major surprise. The buoyancy on this count is a big bonus at a time when the Centre is faced with expenditure stress as a result of war induced disruptions. The rise in both personal and corporate tax collections underscores the economy's resilience to supply shocks and changes in trade policy.

Companies seem to have been able to grow their profitability in the first quarter despite the increase in the cost of fuel, logistics and key inputs for several industries as well as agriculture. This indicates pricing power and healthy demand. Mirroring this counter-intuitive trend, net direct tax collections were up by 16 per cent between April 1 and July 13. The FY27 Budget had assumed a growth of 15 per cent in direct taxes. Direct tax collections took a knock last year, following the cuts in income tax rates announced in the FY26 Budget. The revised estimate for income tax collections in FY26 was 8 per cent lower than the budgeted figure. Therefore, the 12 per cent growth in income tax collections so far this fiscal year implies that lower tax rates are leading to a compliance effect. Higher advance tax payouts for income tax indicate corporate optimism. There was a notable 22 per cent growth in net corporate tax collections (after refunds) and a 16 per cent growth in advance taxes paid by companies.

The Reserve Bank of India's *June Bulletin* points to buoyant demand. To take just a few indices, tractor and two-wheeler sales in rural India rose by over 20 per cent and 15 per cent, respectively, in Q1FY27. GST e-way bill generation grew between 10 and 15 per cent in the first three months of this fiscal, implying that the improvement is broad-based. Petrol and diesel consumption has been rising in volume terms despite the increase in pump prices. Higher domestic demand is also evident in non-food bank credit growing 17.8 per cent in June. The volume and value of digital transactions were up 20 per cent and 15 per cent, respectively, in the first quarter.

In addition, ICRA's business activity monitor index was at a 32-month high in June with 13 of its 16 constituents recording improvement. Automobile sales, including passenger vehicles and two-wheelers, have been robust in the first quarter, with vehicle registrations accelerating 23 per cent in June 2026. Direct taxes have also got a leg-up from securities transaction tax. With trading activity in stock exchanges once again beginning to rise, STT collections have grown at a steep 44 per cent. However, it is too early to extrapolate from these trends for the rest of the year, as several imponderables persist. These include the disruptive effects of an extended war and the prospect of a tepid monsoon. Global trade shocks remain a worry. Yet, initial revenue trends suggest that growth is on track.

OTHER VOICES.

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL. EUROPE

Trump tariffs, more tariffs, and more . . .

Tariffs are an obsession for President Trump, much as climate was for the Biden Administration. How else to explain his imposition of yet another round of border taxes three months before the November election despite their political unpopularity and economic harm? The Administration late Thursday unveiled new tariffs under Section 301 to replace the President's Section 122 tariffs that were lapsing. These latest duties will affect some 60 economies, hitting nearly all US imports, with rates from 10 per cent to 12.5 per cent, and they come on top of a slew of other border taxes. Wait, didn't the Supreme Court strike down Mr. Trump's tariffs in February? Only the emergency tariffs. (NEW YORK, JULY 25)

CHINA DAILY

AI development should be innovative, inclusive

There is now a division in the artificial intelligence development track. Closed-source or open-weight? The choice of AI model is really a choice between two opposing paradigms — on innovation, regulation and who gets a share of the AI pie. The closed-source model seeks to build technical barriers relying on exclusive model weights, locking the dividends of AI progress within a handful of enterprises. Companies such as OpenAI and Anthropic have adopted this path. While this model may deliver quick profits, it shrinks room for innovation and weakens competition. On the other hand, the core value of open-weight models lies in inclusiveness and cooperation. For the industry, such models can break technological monopolies, and make AI more accessible to small and medium-sized businesses. (BEIJING, JULY 26)

LINE & LENGTH.

TCA SRINIVASA RAGHAVAN

FARUQUI AM

Governance: Style and substance

The Modi government can no longer be a hear no evil, see no evil government

As things stand today, it's impossible for my generation not to hark back to 1971-75. Indira Gandhi ruled supreme and in 1972 a weekly in England called her the 'Empress of India' not only because the Congress ruled at the Centre and nearly all the States but also because there was so much popular support for her.

Then in 1973 it all started to go wrong. The movement against her started, ironically, in Gujarat over hostel mess charges and built up into a massive wave of protests and resistance. To make things worse, 1972 and 1973 were drought years. There was an oil crisis because OPEC quadrupled crude oil prices. Inflation was at around 24 per cent and unemployment was rampant. The dreaded Maintenance of Internal Security Act, MISA, had been enacted. And the next general election was three years away.

Today also the next general election, if not brought forward or postponed, is 32 months away. Is this enough time for the Modi government to dampen the increasing grumbling about and against it? Or will this grumbling become sufficiently strong by then to reduce the BJP's seats in the Lok Sabha? It has only 240 now. The answer depends on how the government governs.

Governance has several aspects. One is political and administrative strength, in which this government is not lacking. Another is responsiveness, in which it is totally lacking. A third is political nimbleness, in which it would get 5/10. A fourth is integrity, in which, once again, it would get only 5/10. A fifth is fairness where, even though it does try to act fairly, the overwhelming perception is that it doesn't. A sixth is crisis management in which it would get 9/10.

There are many other things that go towards making governance good, like not equating the government with the country, not indulging in "*suppressio veri, suggestio falsi*", not using strong arm methods to alter parliamentary (and assembly) level support, not learning how to use the press to support policies, like not hating any sort of criticism, not using social media to spread half-truths and so on. It's a long list of morally instigated self-restraint that simply must accompany power.

But let's just take a look at the five main attributes of good governance I listed above. The rest are first and second derivatives from them.

FOCUS AREAS

Political strength is straightforward: the size of the parliamentary majority. But administrative strength is totally different because all Indian governments have to deal with a phenomenon that's peculiarly Indian, the constitutional inability of the boss to sack the servants. The Modi government's political strength has been nearly fully negated by this besetting administrative weakness. Simply put, it hasn't been able to deliver what its parliamentary majority has promised.

That should have made it more responsive both at the group and the individual levels. But the size of the parliamentary majority has induced a sense of invulnerability which has made the government excessively unresponsive or responsive only to pressure groups. The resignation of the education minister could well be a case of too little, too late.

> **Where integrity is concerned, overall it's a more honest government politically but** helpless administratively. But what the voters experience is the latter

Political nimbleness is a part of this and the reason why it scores only 5/10 in this is that it responds only when it fears a loss of votes. Big groups, financial and demographic, are therefore well served and smaller groups are ignored.

Where integrity is concerned, overall it's a more honest government politically but helpless administratively. But what the voters experience is the latter. And the Modi government has failed spectacularly in bringing government employees to heel. Indians have to bribe and bribe and bribe to receive any service from the government.

On fairness, it does far better largely on account of its extensive welfare programmes. These are caste and community blind. Yet it's seen as being anti-minorities because of its ham-handed and appalling methods in uniting the Hindu vote.

Lastly, all governments are always in what a former editor of mine used to call the coping mode. There's always a crisis. On this score, the Modi government has done very well. Even political crises have been handled well enough to prevent them from snowballing. This NEET induced crisis, after the initial mistakes, has been defused.

SO WHAT NEXT?

Nothing, however, wounds and injures politicians more than widespread ridicule and contempt. As it prepares to counter the negative perceptions, a softer approach will go a long way towards rebuilding the trust that now seems gone.

The Modi government can no longer be a hear no evil, see no evil government. It will have to, at the very least, take note of the memes and cartoons about Modi and start listening a bit more. Merely letting Dharmendra Pradhan go won't be enough.

China rebuilding talent pipeline before AI shock hits

Curriculum design is no longer being left to universities. It has become part of national economic and technology strategy

Nimisha Honnalli
Debjani Ghosh

China's higher education reforms have been attracting a lot of attention, mostly framed as a response to graduate unemployment. We don't believe that's the main reason for the reforms. Based on the data and information available, the effort looks far more strategic: China is treating talent as infrastructure, redesigning the pipeline to support its long-term push for technological self-reliance.

Between 2021 and 2025, Chinese universities cut or suspended around 12,200 undergraduate programme points and added roughly 10,200 new ones. More than 30 per cent of undergraduate programmes were affected. One caveat on scale: a "programme point" counts one major at one university, so a single major discontinued across 50 campuses is counted 50 times.

Even so, this was not a routine curriculum update. We see it as China's industrial policy being executed through universities, with a very clear direction: build capacity in areas Beijing considers critical — artificial intelligence, semiconductors, robotics, embodied intelligence, the digital economy, energy and bio-manufacturing, among others. The reform is aimed at producing the engineers, researchers and technical workers China believes it will need over the next decade.

This matters because China has spent two decades expanding higher education. That widened access, but it also created a growing mismatch. Some degrees produced weak employment outcomes, while strategic industries reported severe talent shortages. State-linked estimates point to gaps of more than five million AI workers, 2.3 million big-data workers and over one million workers in new-energy vehicles. China's response has been to intervene before students reach the labour market.

The scale and speed are what make this reform unusual. A 2023 plan set a target to adjust about 20 per cent of university majors by 2025. That target was not only met but exceeded. By the 2026 catalogue cycle, the annual adjustment rate had crossed 10 per cent for the first time, with 38 new majors added in areas such as embodied intelligence and brain-computer science.

HIGHLY COORDINATED

Governance has also tightened. What began as a Ministry of Education initiative moved to the Party level in 2025, when a central action plan was issued for discipline and major adjustment through 2027. That shift is important.

It shows that curriculum design is no longer being treated as an academic matter left to universities. It has become part of national economic and technology strategy.

The cuts are equally revealing. Programmes with weak labour-market outcomes, including parts of the humanities, arts, management, etc., are under greater scrutiny. A red-yellow card system flags majors with persistent employment problems — best understood as a warning-and-correction mechanism rather than a fixed universal rule, since no complete threshold has been published. At the same time, frontier programmes are being concentrated in elite institutions such as Tsinghua, Peking, Zhejiang and Shanghai Jiao Tong, while mid-tier universities expand broader AI and digital offerings. It mirrors China's wider industrial playbook: national champions at the frontier, backed by a broad supply base.

CURRICULUM. Courses with weak labour-market outcomes under scrutiny

The model is highly coordinated, but it is not risk-free.

A centralised push can move too many students into the same fields. A student entering an AI or semiconductor programme in 2026 may graduate around 2030. By then, today's shortages may have narrowed, investment cycles may have shifted, and automation may have reshaped the jobs these students were trained to fill. China could end up correcting one over-expansion by engineering another. There is also a deeper paradox. Many of the technical and white-collar jobs now being prioritised are themselves highly exposed to AI. Programmes will need constant updating, industry feedback and credible pathways for lifelong reskilling.

And, it's too early to call the reform a success. The first large cohorts from the new programmes will not graduate before around 2028.

The lesson for other countries is not that China has found the answer. It is that the growing mismatch between the speed of technological change and the slower rhythms of education policy demands a different approach.

Countries need better talent-intelligence systems connecting employer demand, emerging technologies, education capacity and reskilling — while recognising the limits of forecasting.

China's reforms should therefore be viewed less as a blueprint than as a large-scale experiment in strategic workforce planning. Its significance lies in the question it is attempting to answer: can a country redesign its talent system before technological disruption arrives, without locking students and institutions into assumptions that technology may quickly render obsolete? That is the challenge every major economy will increasingly have to confront.

Nimisha is Young Professional, and Debjani is Distinguished Fellow, NITI Aayog

BELOW THE LINE

Establishment's new act

The latest buzz in Lutyens' Delhi is that after a youth-led protest captured the national imagination, the message from the top was unmistakable: get on Instagram and speak the language of Gen-Z. Ministers have since been encouraged to sharpen their social media presence, with reels and youth-focused content suddenly climbing the political agenda.

The irony, however, is proving irresistible. The establishment is now attempting to borrow the grammar of anti-establishment politics; of irreverence, sarcasm, memes and spontaneity. But that is easier said than done. The protest's appeal lay not in polished production values but in its raw authenticity: handwritten placards, biting humour and a refusal to sound scripted.

As one political observer quipped, "You can learn the platform overnight. You can't manufacture the vibe." The Capital is now waiting to see whether the ruling establishment can convincingly play the outsider; or whether the performance will end up looking exactly what it is: an establishment trying very hard not to look like one.

By appointment only

Power, it seems, comes with access control. A handful of establishment leaders have acquired a reputation for running their offices like high-security zones. Visitors first navigate an online appointment system, then a maze of private security personnel, before confronting successive layers of personal staff. By the time one reaches the minister's door — if at all — the purpose of the visit may well have been forgotten.

The elaborate gatekeeping has become a talking point in Delhi's political circles.

It has even revived an old quip once directed at a former Union minister by a frustrated visitor from his home State: "He's like a *chalanti pratima* of Lord Jagannath — surrounded by *pandas* (temple servitors), and nothing moves unless the keepers are pleased."

Some habits, it appears, outlive governments!

Well prepared!

At a recent earnings press conference of a large bank, after the initial remarks and even before the journalists could get into questions, the Managing Director dived right into details of FCNR (B) deposits they had raised in the last few weeks. This was met with confusion from the journalists' side. "This is all that seems to make headlines these days so I have had my team prepare a detailed note to present to you," the MD said to everyone's amusement.

Our Bureaus

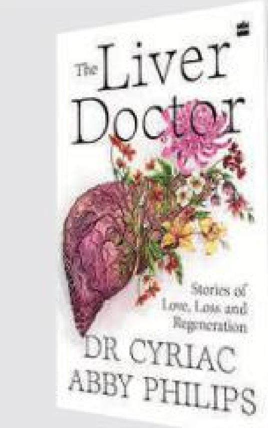
Published by Nirmala Lakshman at No 19&21, Bhagwan Mahaveer Road, Bengaluru-560001 and Printed by C. Sridhar at Plot No. 13-D, Bommasandra-Jigani Link Road, KIADB Industrial Area, Bommasandra, Anekal Taluk, Bengaluru -560099 on behalf of THG PUBLISHING PVT LTD., Chennai-600002. Editor: Raghuvir Srinivasan (Editor responsible for selection of news under the PRP Act). ISSN 0971 - 7528

A doctor's reflective tale

Dispels many notions on liver health, treatment

BOOK REVIEW.

PT Jyothi Datta



Title: The Liver Doctor
Author: Dr Cyriac Abby Philips
Publisher: Harper Non Fiction
Price: ₹499

The opening pages of *The Liver Doctor* reveal a thinking that may not quite sit with the online persona of its author Dr Cyriac Abby Philips.

"From the time you are born, Death becomes your friend. The only one destined to advance towards you and finally embrace you. Death is your friend. Always has been," he says, on the journey of a medical professional, dealing with death at some point. "I became a doctor not to help people cheat Death but to prepare them to understand it and, in the process, learn the value of embracing life," he writes, rather sensitively.

The online persona of the doctor, though, is a polarising one calling out traditional systems of medicine, in a manner that appears to pander to the gladiatorial audience on social media, rather than engage in a civil scientific argument, more becoming of a respected doctor. Perhaps his book gives readers an idea of why that is.

Initially, he did engage on microblogging site Twitter (now X) to explain liver health. He was surprised with its "power to change public perception and spark meaningful dialogue..." But his first encounter, "was not entirely pleasant", he says.

His stated purpose was to share insights on liver injuries and the risks of alternative medicines. But that brought on the trolls and he was called a host of things, including a "big-pharma endorser" for discussing studies that slammed Ayurvedic therapies, he recalls.

STORIES OF PATIENTS

Overwhelmed by the abuse, he took a pause and came back — only to find that Twitter (X) had not changed, but the way he communicated with the "often harsh crowd" had, he says, as he started sharing stories of patient families — on herbal liver injuries, liver diseases, drug-induced injuries, and effects of alcohol. These were stories of "challenging diagnoses and exhausting battles fought within hospital walls — sometimes ending in the loss of a patient".

This pattern reflects in his book too, as he takes us through the stories of 14-year-old SaiKrishna, who came in "jaundiced and lethargic". Hailing from a lower-economic background, and possibly needing an expensive (₹25 lakh) liver transplant — the doctor takes us through his medical journey and his assessment of the damage caused by anti-seizure syrups, prescribed by an ayurvedic practitioner. There is also the incident of Shankar, and his recurrent brain failures — his treatment, getting discharged from hospital after three weeks and throwing the "Kayam Churna (that he was consuming as a laxative) out of the window".

Unlike the doctor's approach on Twitter (X), the book is readable, and the patient stories delve into liver conditions and products that trigger health issues. The finger-pointing of ayurvedic products continues, and it comes with explanations.

While the patient stories outline the doctor and his patients' experiences — with reasoning that's insightful — a reader with a scientific mind is left searching for more detail to connect the dots.

For example, in the case of modern medicine, a drug is prescribed to treat a specific problem, prescribed for a period of time, followed-up with diagnostic tests to monitor outcomes.

The book does not seem to indicate if the traditional products prescribed to his patients were indicated for a limited time, to be monitored thereafter. That question lingers. Indiscriminate use of any product, traditional or otherwise, could lead to disastrous outcomes. As doctors themselves will tell you, no medicine is without a side-effect.

That said, the book is engaging and reveals aspects of traditional products that are not often explained in as many words. As a doctor's journey, it reveals moments of vulnerability that doctors often bury and soldier on.

A timely portrait of Karnataka's CM

The book captures the man of the moment, but could have been clearer on facts and provided an in-depth look at some aspects

BOOK REVIEW.

Venkatesha Babu

In the cacophonous democracy that India is, it is a pity that we do not have more books chronicling political leaders, parties and defining moments in the world's largest democracy. Political biographies and insider accounts remain surprisingly few and far between.

Rasheed Kidwai, a veteran Congress watcher with impeccable credentials and deep access to the party's top leadership, is well placed to tell such stories. His latest book, *Congress's Crisis Manager, Karnataka's Kingmaker: DK Shivakumar*, arrives at a particularly opportune moment. After nearly three years of intense speculation and internal manoeuvring, the Congress high command finally persuaded Siddaramaiah to step down and elevated Shivakumar as Karnataka's Chief Minister in June this year.

The book traces Shivakumar's journey from student politics to the State's highest office, peppering the narrative with anecdotes and insider accounts. However, for long-time observers of Karnataka politics, much of the material will already be familiar. The Ahmed Patel Rajya Sabha election of 2017 and the episode involving the sequestering of 44 Gujarat Congress MLAs at Bengaluru's Eagleton Resort receive extensive attention — perhaps more than they warrant, given how often these incidents have already been recounted.

The author argues that Shivakumar has emerged as the tallest Vokkaliga leader after former Prime Minister HD Deve Gowda. That conclusion appears premature. While Deve Gowda, now 93, is in the twilight of his political career, his son HD Kumaraswamy remains an active and influential force. Having already served twice as Chief Minister, Kumaraswamy has an equally strong claim to leadership within the community.

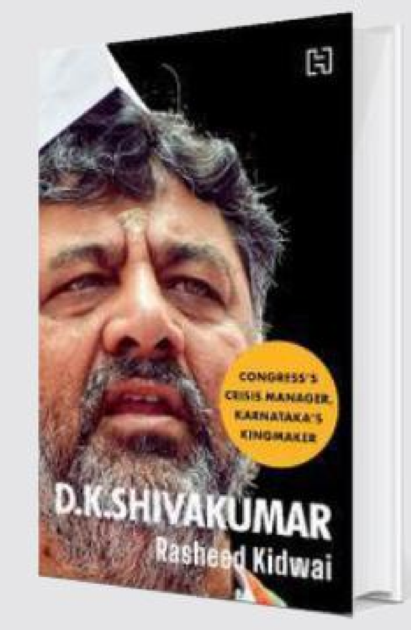
The book is also inconsistent in its demographic estimates. It cites Lingayats as constituting 21 per cent of Karnataka's population at one point, while elsewhere placing the figure between 11 and 17 per cent. Similarly, Vokkaligas are variously estimated at between 10 and 15 per cent. Some uncertainty is understandable because successive governments have refrained from officially releasing the findings of the State's caste survey. The reluctance is widely attributed to concerns that the actual demographic weight of the dominant communities may differ significantly from long-held assumptions.

A CONGRESS STRONGHOLD

Kidwai perhaps overstates the centrality of Siddaramaiah and his clever co-option of AHINDA (Kannada acronym for minorities, backward classes and Dalits) coalition in explaining Congress's success. Historically, Karnataka has been one of the Congress's strongest States. Even when the BJP has formed governments, the Congress has often secured a higher share of the popular vote. In 2008, for instance, the Congress polled marginally more votes than the BJP, yet the BJP formed its first government in the State. The pattern repeated in 2018, when the Congress again secured a higher vote share but emerged with fewer seats because of the first-past-the-post electoral system.

Equally debatable is the suggestion that the Congress has sought to shift Karnataka's politics from caste-based mobilisation to issue-based politics. The State's electoral politics continues to be deeply shaped by identity. If the BJP has attempted to consolidate voters around religious identity, the Congress has focused on caste coalitions while relying heavily on support from minority communities.

One charming anecdote recounts Shivakumar's sister, Manjula, showing her hand to a fortune-teller and recounting this to her brother who retorted, "Why show your palm to know your future? You should shape your own future." It is an admirable sentiment, although it sits uneasily with Shivakumar's own well-known belief in astrology and fortune-telling.



Title: DK Shivakumar: Congress's Crisis Manager, Karnataka's Kingmaker
Author: Rasheed Kidwai
Publisher: Hachette
Price: ₹699

The book also creates an impression that Shivakumar emerged from an impoverished rural background. That portrayal is only partly accurate. Shivakumar himself has acknowledged on several occasions that his family was relatively well-off. His education at institutions such as National Public School and Vidyavardhaka Sangha — among Bengaluru's better-known schools at the time — suggests a family with considerable means.

Similarly, the book portrays Shivakumar as an unwavering loyalist of the Gandhi family throughout his political career. The reality is somewhat more nuanced. In 1994, after being denied a Congress ticket, he contested as an Independent and won, before eventually returning to the party fold.

One notable omission is the controversy surrounding the proposed 114-foot statue of Jesus Christ at Kapalabetta in Kanakapura. On Christmas Day in 2019, Shivakumar participated in the foundation-laying ceremony and contributed over ₹10 lakh to the project. The BJP alleged that the site was a hill sacred to Lord Shiva and that government land had been illegally earmarked for the monument. The project became embroiled in legal disputes and eventually faded from public attention.

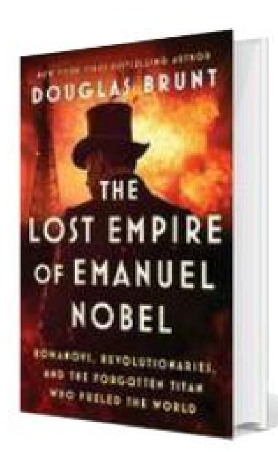
There are also factual inaccuracies. On page 51, Veerappa Moily is described as a Vokkaliga leader, whereas he belongs to the Devadiga community.

While the book briefly touches upon Shivakumar's business interests — particularly in education and real estate — it stops well short of examining the remarkable expansion of his wealth. His declared assets increased from ₹251.51 crore in his 2013 Assembly election affidavit to ₹1,413.8 crore in 2023, making him one of India's wealthiest elected politicians. A dedicated chapter examining this aspect of his public life would have substantially strengthened the book.

Where Kidwai is at his best is in narrating developments within the Congress at the national level. His account of the Indira Gandhi era and the political manoeuvring within the party's central leadership is engaging, authoritative and highly readable.

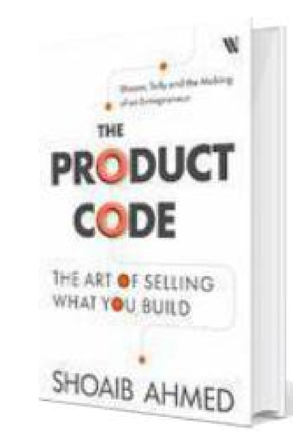
Ultimately though, the book is a timely and worthwhile read. It provides useful insights into Shivakumar's political evolution but falls short of offering the definitive biography that such an important political figure deserves.

NEW READS.



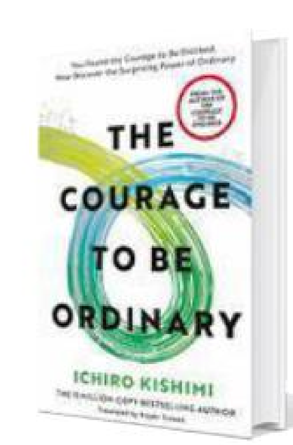
Title: The Lost Empire of Emanuel Nobel
Author: Douglas Brunt
Publisher: Atria Books

The book chronicles one of the most influential men in history — a man whose name has been stricken from memory is thrillingly returned to life



Title: The Product Code
Author: Shoaib Ahmed
Publisher: Westland Business

The author shares a two-pronged formula for success: building software that solves real-world human problems and nurturing human relationships



Title: The Courage to be Ordinary
Author: Ichiro Kishimi
Publisher: Vermilion

Being ordinary isn't failure — it's freedom. Freedom from constant competition, from chasing approval, from feeling habitually tense

thehindubusinessline.

TWENTY YEARS AGO TODAY.

July 27, 2006

Govt does not endorse RIL gas price formula

The Government did not agree with the Mukesh Ambani led Reliance Industries' proposed valuation formula for gas sales to Reliance Natural Resources Ltd belonging to Anil Ambani Group. The Petroleum Ministry said it has not been derived on the basis of competitive arm's length sale pricing.

CBI awaits Govt nod to book officials in corruption cases

The Central Bureau of Investigation has stepped up its anti-corruption drive in the past three-and-a-half years with the number of corruption cases registered by it going up significantly each year since 2003. . According to the rules, the CBI needs the sanction from the Ministry concerned to initiate proceedings in case of officials in the rank of Joint Secretary and above.

Street vendors demand to be organised

The roadside hawker is no insignificant entity. In a rough estimate, they contribute ₹86,000-crore annually to the country's GDP. Demanding the creation of a Task Force to implement the street vendor national policy, over 270 hawkers from all over the country congregated at the All India Street Vendors Jansunwayi (public hearing).

Short take

India-UK CETA will give a boost to auto-parts sector

Vikrampati Singhania

On July 15, 2026, as the India-UK Comprehensive Economic and Trade Agreement (CETA) came into effect, the Government of India flagged off one of the first export consignments under the Agreement. The consignment was from Brakes India, an Indian automotive components manufacturer.

It underscored the growing stature of India's automotive components industry and the confidence that Indian companies have earned in global markets through decades of investment in quality, technology and engineering excellence.

In many ways, that first shipment marked the beginning of a new chapter, one in which India is increasingly recognised not merely as a competitive manufacturing destination, but as a trusted partner in shaping the future of global mobility.

The India-UK CETA provides the foundation for a deeper manufacturing partnership that combines India's scale and manufacturing competitiveness with the UK's strengths in advanced engineering, innovation and technology. The timing is significant. As the global automotive industry navigates geopolitical uncertainty, supply chain realignments and rapid tech change, trusted partnerships have become as important as competitive costs.

India's automotive components industry enters this new phase from a position of strength. Today, it is a \$86 billion industry with exports of \$24 billion, reflecting decades of investment in engineering capability, quality systems and manufacturing excellence.

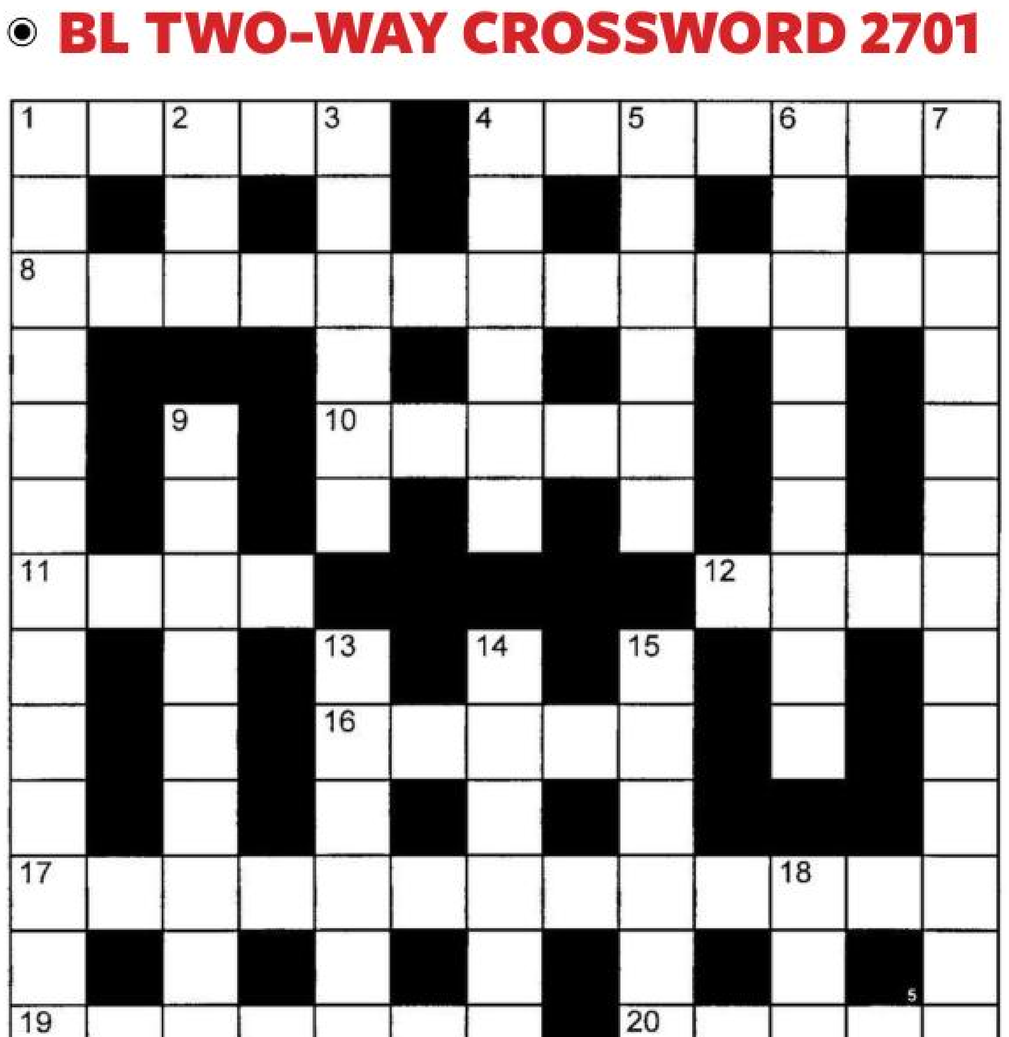
The UK is already an important partner. Automotive components export to the UK grew by nearly 11 per cent during FY26 to \$801 million, highlighting the complementarity between the two industries. India has emerged as a globally competitive supplier across a broad spectrum of automotive products, while the UK remains a leader in advanced engineering, research, testing, design and next-generation mobility technologies. Together, these strengths create opportunities far beyond bilateral trade. As the industry transitions towards electric, connected and software-defined vehicles, the partnership can accelerate innovation, attract investment and strengthen resilient global supply chains.

For India's MSMEs, the agreement offers an opportunity to deepen technology partnerships, upgrade capabilities and integrate more closely with global value chains. Ultimately, the success of the India-UK CETA will be measured not by tariff reductions alone, but by the supplier relationships, technologies, investments and globally competitive products it helps create.

The first consignment under the Agreement may have carried automotive components, but it also carried the confidence, capability and global aspirations of India's automotive components industry.

The writer is President ACMA and Vice Chairman and MD, JK Fenner (India) Ltd

BL TWO-WAY CROSSWORD 2701



EASY

ACROSS

1. (Bear the) shock, force of blow (5)
4. Lateen-sailed Mediterranean ship (7)
8. Spoiling oneself too much (13)
10. Find solution (5)
11. Requirement (4)
12. At an altitude (4)
16. Hooded shirt, coat (5)
17. Giving to the public welfare (13)
19. Goes on vexing, embittering (7)
20. List of jurors (5)

DOWN

1. Material for soaking up excess ink (8,5)
2. Employment (3)
3. A desire for drink (6)
4. Violin (6)
5. Composed, soothed (6)
6. Disposition to believe (9)
7. Of the science of heavenly bodies (13)
9. Exactness, minute accuracy (9)
13. Spread stragglingly (6)
14. For nothing, free (6)
15. A powerful, ostentatious, rich governor (6)
18. Peg, nail (3)

NOT SO EASY

ACROSS

1. Being so burnt is a shock to be borne (5)
4. Cue calf that could be under sail in the Mediterranean (7)
8. Pampering one too much with gold : unit never changes (13)
10. Find an answer to love's entanglement (5)
11. Have to have been born a woman, a daughter (4)
12. Is well up the scale – of being drunk? (4)
16. Hyde had a windproof garment such as this (5)
17. Benevolent chap in RH plot one sorted out (13)
19. It goes on irritating the right joints (7)
20. Board with switches in a different plane (5)

DOWN

1. GP, able to print something as absorbing as this (8,5)
2. Custom one may turn to one's advantage (3)
3. T-shirt designed to show it being satisfied with a drink (6)
4. It is something to bow and scrape, but it's a swindle (6)
5. Soothed by three quid due to be handed out (6)
6. Willingness to believe it ruled out in the City (9)
7. It's about star study (ps : Charity also comes into it) (13)
9. Accuracy in price is no substitute for it (9)
13. Lie untidily, with paws flung left and right (6)
14. Deserter is being held by American soldiers for nothing (6)
15. Leave one another as he turns up, the tyrant (6)
18. One's debit card number may have its point (3)

SOLUTION: BL TWO-WAY CROSSWORD 2700

ACROSS 1. Stood 4. Through 8. Overslept 9. Par 10. Lookout 12. Tree 14. Demoted 17. Bias 18. Paddock 20. All 21. Embroider 23. Entreat 24. Model

DOWN 1. Shoulder blade 2. Oberon 3. Discover 4. Tee 5. Ruth 6. Umpire 7. Horse mackerel 11. Troop 13. Headroom 15. Wallet 16. Sordid 19. Cede 22. Bat

BENGALURU
businessline.
MONDAY - JULY 27 - 2026

ON THE CAMPAIGN TRAIL.

Humour, nostalgia and a return to simplicity powered some of the campaigns we saw in the past fortnight

A life with colour

Berger Paints' new campaign unveiled a refreshed brand identity anchored in a simple belief: Whatever life may test us with, it should never take away our colour. The campaign 'Rang Bana Rahe' is as much a perspective on life as it is on paints, celebrating the way in which people hold on to their colours of individuality and spirit. At the centre of the campaign is a circus artist — a clown named Khushrangi, whose colours never fade, come rain or shine. Through the depiction of a day in his life, the film created by Sideways Consulting shows how people and even homes can hold on to their colours.

Praise without words

Greenlam Laminates' new film, 'Taareefein Dikhai Dengi', created by Dentsu Creative Webchutney, draws on the insight that while people are quick to voice opinions, they are often reserved with compliments. Using the old film song '*Na Bole Tum, Na Maine Kuch Kaha*' as a metaphor for appreciation that needs no words, the film shows a couple welcoming friends to their renovated home. The guests are left speechless by the interiors crafted with Greenlam Laminates and, for the couple, the stares are appreciation enough. Significantly, the ad is in a longer format at 45 seconds and 60 seconds, instead of 30 seconds, stemming from the brand's belief that good stories cannot be rushed.

Back to basics

Jyothy Labs' new campaign for its bioenzyme-powered anti-bacterial EXO range of dishwashing solutions, created by a simple agency, a unit of Loggerheads, uses a dual-voice strategy to build stronger connections with audiences across the country. Yami Gautam leads the communication across North, East and West India, while Keerthy Suresh becomes the voice of the brand in the southern states. The campaign keeps the product firmly at the heart of the story, and drills home — very simply — how well the dishwashing liquid does its job.

The death trap

Most road safety campaigns tell drivers what they are doing wrong. SaveLIFE Foundation's latest behaviour change campaign, 'Nuksaan Ka Sauda', focuses on the 'why'. The seven-film digital series, with creative development by McCann Worldgroup, shows that many road crashes happen not because of recklessness or indifference but pure economics. In an attempt to save every penny, the average Indian compromises — from using cheap helmets to overloading vehicles — not realising it can be fatal. Three of the films feature hyperlocal content creators drawn from the truck driving, cab driving and motorcyclist communities.

NUGGETS.

From chips to cafes

In March this year, snack brand Lays, from the Pepsico stable, launched Pilla Tortilla in Madrid, an eatery serving traditional Spanish tortillas using the brand's crisps as a core ingredient. In April this year, it opened Lay's Potato Restaurant in Shanghai, in the Xintiandi lifestyle district, offering potato-inspired dishes, fashion collaborations and exclusive merchandise. According to VML Intelligence, snack brands searching for growth outside retail shelves are increasingly vying for a share of the consumer's weekend by investing in restaurants. Haldiram's, in India, is a veteran in that concept and has recently expanded into London with a 120-seat eatery.

Tuning in free

Despite music being among the most consumed forms of digital entertainment in India, paid music streaming remains significantly underpenetrated, according to a report by EY and the Indian Music Industry (IMI), titled 'How India listens, streams and pays for music'. It estimates India had about 14 million paid music subscriptions in 2025 and this could touch 28–30 million by 2028, supported by product innovation, partnerships and evolving consumer preferences. The report, surveying about 15,000 smartphone users across India, found a substantial gap between consumption and monetisation. While 86 per cent pay for video OTT services at some point, only 38 per cent pay for a music streaming service.

BIG SCREEN REBOUND

Popcorn, premium seats and mega hits

FULL HOUSE. H1 2026 marks the highest post-pandemic cinema revenue, driven by advance sales and surging demand for luxury formats

ACTION! (From left) Top grosser *Dhurandhar: The Revenge*; *The Odyssey* earned ₹100 crore within a week; and a newly opened theatre in Tiruchi, as the movie market booms in tier-2 centres and beyond

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani

From luxury seating to packed single screens, India's box office is witnessing a historic, post-pandemic surge this year. Christopher Nolan's *The Odyssey*, which crossed ₹100 crore in gross collections within the first week of its release, is just the latest blockbuster riding the wave. What's remarkable is the broad-based growth across Hindi, Hollywood and regional language films, making it the highest grossing first half of any year post Covid. With a strong line-up of films in the second half, the year promises to be a milestone one for movie ticket sales, which are expected to cross the ₹15,000 crore mark, according to Ormax Media.

PVR INOX's investor presentation states that box-office collections in India grew 20 per cent in the January-June period to ₹6,665 crore from ₹5,570 crore a year ago, outpacing international markets.

What enthuses Sanjeev Kumar Bijli, Executive Director, PVR INOX, is the growth beyond metros in tier-2 and tier-3 markets. "Consumers are coming to watch not just the big-budget films but also the mid-scale and small films that are not star-driven," he said.

BOX-OFFICE BOOM

Notes Bijli, "Films that are now touching the ₹100 crore mark were, even two years ago, stopping at ₹30-40 crore. *Main Vaapas Aaunga* has grossed nearly ₹100 crore. A horror English film like *Obsession* also garnered ₹100 crore. These are all sleeper hits, and such smaller movies earning nearly ₹100 crore is a very positive sign."

He points to how star-driven films like *Bhoot Bangla* are garnering over ₹200 crore. At the same time, regional cinema is witnessing multi-fold growth.

Earlier this month, the Multiplex Association of India, too, had pointed out that a healthy mix of blockbuster franchises, original stories, regional cinema and international releases had resonated with audiences across India in the first half of the year.

According to Ormax Media, *Dhurandhar: The Revenge* and *Border 2* in Hindi and *Peddi* in Telugu were the top three grossers in the January-June period. Six films crossed the ₹200 crore mark, compared to four a year ago, the media consulting firm said.

Project Hail Mary and *Obsession* were among the top 15 grossers, indicating the strong run enjoyed by Hollywood productions in India; the hype surrounding *The Odyssey* and *Spider-Man: Brand New Day* is further proof of this.

AUDIENCE ADVOCACY

Devang Sampat, MD, Cinepolis India, said, "After a strong performance in H1 and, given the robust content pipeline for the second half of the year, we expect to see this year's box-office collection outperforming historical benchmarks. The internal metric we closely monitor is the number of consumers visiting the cinema... The million-plus-footfall movies have been growing year-on-year."

Echoing this, Ashish Saksena, COO-Cinemas, BookMyShow, said India's movie theatre success is no longer driven by one language or genre. "We've seen greater stability in box-office trends compared to the immediate post-pandemic years. Rather than relying on one or two tent-pole releases, we're seeing a wider mix of films sustaining theatrical momentum through audience advocacy and positive word-of-mouth," he said. "*Main Vaapas Aaunga*, for instance, continued to perform steadily in cinemas weeks after release, despite audiences knowing it would eventually arrive on OTT."

Movies like *Dhurandhar: The Revenge*, *Jana Nayagan* in Tamil and *The Odyssey* have seen stellar advance bookings. "Consumers are increasingly booking tickets earlier, driven by anticipation around upcoming releases, rather than waiting for reviews or word of mouth, which reflects a growing confidence in today's theatrical slate. Another encouraging indicator is the gradual pickup in weekend business across a wider range of films," Saksena said.

PREMIUMISATION

Leading multiplex chains are adding screens. "There is a lot of headroom for growth. We are looking at adding 40 screens per year across the key catchments, irrespective of whether it is tier-1, tier-2 or metro," said Sampat.

Movie-goers are increasingly value conscious rather than price conscious, driving a premiumisation trend. "*The Odyssey* is a great example of this shift. Many audiences chose to wait to experience the film in IMAX rather than watching in a standard format," said Saksena, adding this is driving investments in upgrading the exhibition ecosystem, including sound, projection and overall in-cinema experiences. Moreover, globally, filmmakers are increasingly designing films that are best experienced in the premium formats.

"Almost 20 per cent of our circuit is premium screens like IMAX, 4DX, ICE, ScreenX, Insignia and Director's Cut. These formats offer a more immersive experience, and we are committed to expanding them as consumers are willing to pay more for the differentiation," Bijli said.

The big-ticket line-up for the second half of the year, including *Ramayana: Part 1*, *King*, *Toxic*, *Fauzi*, *Jailer 2*, *Avengers: Doomsday* and *Spider-Man: Brand New Day*, promises to keep the cash registers ringing for longer.

DESIGNING DESIRE

When brands make you sleuth around to discover them

Vatsala Bisen

When we stand in a supermarket or scroll through e-commerce, the hand always moves faster than the mind and the best kind of brands understand this. They don't want you to know, they want you to wonder.

Take, for example, the mobile phone landscape of 2022. Every major tech giant was engaged in a desperate race for technical specs. The air was thick with megapixels, battery capacities and imaging chips. So, what could a new entrant even say at this time to be heard? Carl Pei decided it was "Nothing". He simply posted a few visual clues on X and let the internet do its thing. The phone debuted at an exhibition in Basel, like some piece of art. And sold over half a million units in the first five months.

AWAKENING CURIOSITY

This is the deliberate mastery of strategic desire. The most magnetic brands in the world understand that explaining your product is often the fastest way to kill the magic. What you really need to do is create something that hits the lizard brain first, compelling us to lean in and ask: "I like it. What is it?"

Take the retro-futuristic toy-like design of the Swedish tech brand Teenage Engineering, which makes cult-classic audio products, aesthetic synthesisers and dynamic performance sequencers. The shiny chrome-and-orange body, with mysterious dials and no instructions, makes us want to hold it, flip it and rush to show it to our friends. We may not know how to sequence a beat but we sure want to collect them all.

It can also be used to flip the script — building desire for products for which we have developed a blind spot. For generations, canned fish was a pantry staple hidden on the lowest supermarket shelves. Founded and led by a woman, the company Fishwife, which sells ethically sourced tinned seafood, took this dusty category and wrapped it in vibrant, hand-illustrated boxes that look like pop art. Lo and behold! Instagram found a new darling. Fishwife's colourful boxes now appear on kitchen counters for the love of aesthetic joy. The tinned fish just happens to be inside it. Or how Graza, based in Brooklyn, US, playfully disrupted the olive oil category with a vibrant, squeezy green bottle, leading to a whole host of me-toos.

SOLD ON AESTHETICS. Fishwife seafood, and a Total Environment home

And sometimes desire comes from stubborn opacity. Luxury cosmetics brand Aesop's stores carry a refusal to explain. Customers are made to feel like they are being invited into someone's home and, before you know it, you are washing your hands at their central stone basin and rearranging your whole home to match the two bottles on your bathroom shelf.

CATERING TO TASTE

Closer home, take Total Environment. For decades, Indian real estate sold through brute-force aspiration, focusing on marble lobbies, infinity pools and names like 'Grandeur' or 'Elysium'. Total Environment bypassed the mega-phone, not bothering with introductions. It built homes where banyan trees burst through living rooms and rainwater cascaded down interior walls. But the real mastery of desire was in the naming. Instead of selling status, they catered to taste. The building names were centred around music and other aesthetics — 'In That Quiet Earth', 'Windmills of Your Mind' and 'Down by the Water'. It created an instant insider view. If you got the reference, you were one of them. It shifted the needle from 'showing' to 'knowing'.

Awareness is what you rent. Desire is what you own. Most brands are paying extraordinary rates for rented attention, but true innovators prefer to make you sleuth. By stepping back and leaving room for curiosity, they transform their product from an item to be sold to a treasure to be discovered. Because, ultimately, the most powerful question a brand can generate should not be "What do you do?", but the far more compelling "Where did you get that?"

Vatsala Bisen is Executive Creative Director, OPEN Strategy & Design

Every weekend is now a time of festive spending and cheer

How urban India's booming weekend economy is a huge opportunity for marketers and city planners

THE CURIOUS MARKETER

HARISH BHAT

On a recent Saturday evening, I was at Church Street in central Bengaluru. It was virtually impossible to walk on this road because it was jam-packed with hundreds of shoppers and revellers. There were long queues to get into restaurants. The nearby metro station was teeming with people. It looked like a festival day, though it was just another weekend.

Then, on Sunday afternoon, I attended a talk on quantum physics, given by a friend. It was held at a pub in Koramangala, with entry priced above ₹1,000 per person, inclusive of snacks. I was surprised to see a full house — more than 120 people — all totally engaged, with intellect and food. The talk was fabulous. Once again, just another weekend in Bangalore.

A day later, the penny dropped when I read an excellent report, 'The many urban Indias', published by PRICE and Tata Sons, and authored by Rajesh Shukla, Roopa Purushothaman and Vishal Vaibhaw. A key observation was the emergence of the 'weekend economy' in urban India.

The report highlighted how, on average, urban consumers spend ₹6,724 during weekdays and ₹10,732 each weekend. This implies that 61.5 per cent of weekly spending is concentrated on just Saturday and Sunday.

Spending on discretionary products — fashion and apparel, entertainment and electronics — virtually doubles during weekends. Spending on essential items — groceries and healthcare — also moves higher during weekends, though moderately. This weekend splurge is seen across the top 100 cities, not just metros.

Why are weekends so big?

What has driven this big shift to the urban weekend economy? My hypothesis is there are three key reasons for it.

■ First, with dual-income households far more common in Indian cities, families have little or no time to spend money meaningfully on weekdays because of long hours at work and travel. Similarly, children are tied up with school, tuitions and other activities. This leaves only weekends for shopping, family outings or other leisure experiences.

LISTEN UP. A live music show keeps weekend crowds engaged at a pedestrian-first space in Chennai VELANKANNI RAJ B

■ Second, there is a distinct mindset change when people enter weekends — we want to let our hair down and spend on experiences that recharge our physical and emotional batteries. This contrasts with the hectic weekday, where productivity is the key goal. In short, the weekday urbanite is psychographically different from the weekend urbanite.

■ Third, in today's digital-fuelled world, people are constantly seeking hits of adrenaline. On weekdays, they get these hits from work, and interactions with colleagues. Come weekend, they need to escape to nearby resorts or eat fancy meals or indulge in shopping therapy to obtain their shots of pleasure.

So, what can marketers and cities do to ride this weekend wave? Here are some thoughts.

Retail stores can stay open longer on weekends, and cities can facilitate this. Recently, I saw a store turn away a customer who came in around 9 pm on Sunday evening. Retail stores can also design special experiences for customers over the weekends — such as nail art or *mehendi* or Mediterranean cooking classes — which can prove very engaging. Brands can also create customised weekend engagement programmes.

Cities can demarcate weekend zones, with permission for activities such as busking, food vending, street theatre, book readings and art displays. Public transport, sanitation, road lighting and safety can be stepped up to ensure people have access to reliable, cost-effective travel and feel safe on roads, particularly during late hours.

With imagination, city planners and marketers can transform each of the 52 weekends during the year into win-win festivals that engage people beautifully and also generate significant incremental economic activity.

Harish Bhat is an avid marketer and bestselling author

FROM THE LABS.

Additive steps up lubrication

Scientists have shown, for the first time, that borophene — an ultra-thin, two-dimensional nanomaterial — can be used as an effective additive to improve the performance of castor oil as a lubricant. The discovery could help develop greener lubricants for industries such as renewable energy, marine transport and sustainable manufacturing.

Researchers at the Institute of Advanced Study in Science and Technology (IASST), Guwahati, found that adding a tiny amount of borophene — 0.1 per cent by weight — to castor oil can significantly improve its performance. The modified oil reduced friction by about 42 per cent, compared with ordinary castor oil.

The research was carried out under the guidance of Prof Devasish Chowdhury, with INSPIRE senior research fellow Ujjibit Boruah as the first author. The findings could lead to the development of environment friendly lubricants that make machines run more efficiently, reduce damage and lower energy consumption.

"Two-dimensional materials have attracted huge interest because of their unique properties. Borophene, in particular, has shown promise in areas such as batteries, supercapacitors and fuel cells. However, its use as a lubricant additive had not been explored until now," said Prof Chowdhury.

The researchers found that borophene mixes evenly with castor oil without needing any chemical treatment. When the lubricant is used inside machines, the borophene particles help form a thin protective layer, called tribofilm, on metal surfaces. This layer contains iron oxides, carbon-based compounds and boron compounds. It reduces friction between moving surfaces, allows machines to handle higher loads and protects against wear.

Next-gen battery electrode

Researchers in India have developed a new organic electrode material that could help accelerate the development of sodium-ion batteries, a promising alternative to lithium-ion batteries for largescale energy storage.

As demand for batteries grows for electric vehicles, renewable energy storage and electronic devices, researchers worldwide are looking for alternatives to lithium, which faces challenges related to cost, supply chains and resource availability. Sodium, in contrast, is widely available, making sodium-ion batteries an attractive option.

A joint team from the Indian Association for the Cultivation of Science (IACS) and SN Bose National Centre for Basic Sciences (SNBNCBS), Kolkata, has developed a new covalent organic framework (COF) material that can store sodium ions efficiently.

The team, led by Dr Urmimala Maitra of IACS and Dr Pradip Pachfule of SNBNCBS, designed the porous organic material to allow charged ions to move easily while maintaining structural stability during repeated charging and discharging.

When tested in battery cells, the material demonstrated good energy storage performance and its ability to work as an electrode for sodium-ion batteries. The material also performs well in lithium-ion batteries, enabling rapid charging, with the laboratory cell reaching 80 per cent charge in just over one minute.

The material's porous structure provides pathways through which ions can travel quickly, while its stable chemical framework helps prevent degradation during cycling. This combination of rapid ion transport and durability is a key challenge in designing next-generation battery electrodes.

The study highlights how molecular-level design of organic materials can help overcome some of the limitations of sodium-ion batteries, which currently lag lithium-ion batteries in energy density and commercial maturity.

◉ REPURPOSING FURNACES

Tata Steel's coke-cutting EASyMelt tech

CLEAN TRANSITION. Company explores pathway to reducing coke usage while retaining existing steel-making infrastructure

M Ramesh

In April this year, Tata Steel put out a brief announcement stating it had "entered into definitive agreements with Paul Wurth, SA (Luxembourg), part of SMS Group GmbH, for implementation of the world's first EASyMelt (electrically assisted syngas smelter) technology".

Behind the jargon lies an ambitious attempt to tackle one of the hardest problems in industrial decarbonisation: How to reduce emissions from existing blast furnaces without replacing the furnaces altogether?

CARBON-INTENSIVE. In a blast furnace, the heat balance is maintained through reactions involving coke BLOOMBERG

The blast furnace remains the dominant means of producing iron globally. EASyMelt modifies the furnace to help use the gases emitted during the various segments of steel making to convert iron ore to iron. This significantly reduces dependence on coke, the indispensable ingredient in steel making that is also responsible for much of the carbon dioxide emissions from steel plants.

However, the process of producing coke from coal — heating metallurgical coal in coke ovens — is also rich in hydrogen and methane.

Tata Steel believes EASyMelt could offer a pathway to reducing coke consumption while retaining much of the existing steel-making infrastructure.

Subodh Pandey, VP Technology, R&D, NMB and Graphene, told *businessline* that EASyMelt represents a combination of three process improvement technologies that have been demonstrated individually elsewhere but never integrated in this manner before.

- The first step is dry reforming, which creates the reducing gas needed by the blast furnace.

An integrated steel plant produces several gases. One of them is coke oven gas, generated during the production of coke from coal. Rather than being simply burnt as fuel, coke oven gas can be used as a chemical feedstock because it contains large quantities of hydrogen and methane. "Coke oven gas is gold," said Pandey.

The methane in coke oven gas is reacted with carbon dioxide from blast furnace gas in a dry reformer. The reaction converts these gases into synthesis gas (syngas), a mixture primarily containing carbon monoxide and hydrogen — the very gases that help reduce iron ore (by driving out the oxygen in the ore).

In effect, a gas that would otherwise contain a significant amount of carbon dioxide is converted into a fresh stream of reducing gases.

- The second process is shaft injection. In a conventional blast furnace, most reducing gases enter from the bottom and travel upwards. Shaft injection introduces the newly produced reducing gas higher up in the furnace.

This allows the iron ore burden to begin losing oxygen earlier in its journey through the furnace, reducing the chemical work needed in the hottest region below.

- The third process is tuyere injection. Tuyeres are water-cooled nozzles located near the bottom of the blast furnace, through which hot gases are normally blown into the furnace. This is the zone where coke combustion generates high temperatures and the carbon monoxide required for iron making.

By injecting reducing gases through the tuyeres, EASyMelt supplies carbon monoxide and hydrogen directly to the region where reduction is most intensive. This reduces the need for coke to generate those gases inside the furnace.

THERMAL SHIFT

"The idea is that, instead of making all the reducing gases inside the furnace using coke, we make them outside and inject them back in," Pandey explained. The "electrically assisted" component of EASyMelt refers to the use of electrically generated heat to raise the temperature of the reducing gases before they are injected into the blast furnace. In a conventional furnace, the heat balance is maintained largely through carbon-based reactions involving coke. By shifting a part of the thermal requirement to electricity, EASyMelt seeks to cut the reliance on carbon for both chemical reduction and heat generation.

Subodh Pandey, VP Technology, R&D, NMB and Graphene, Tata Steel

The company's board has approved an investment of ₹2,500 crore to modify a blast furnace at its Jamshedpur facility for the deployment of the EASyMelt technology.

Pandey, however, cautioned that the coke reduction figure is an expectation, which will be tested through the project. "Our bet is that coke consumption should fall from 440 kg per tonne of hot metal to 220 kg," he said. That would imply nearly 50 per cent reduction in coke consumption, if achieved.

EASyMelt was developed by SMS Group, the global equipment supplier, which approached Tata Steel with the technology.

"We had the appetite to try out this new approach," Pandey said.

The Jamshedpur project could also be the beginning of a wider rollout within Tata Steel's operations. Pandey said he believed that around 20 per cent of the company's blast furnaces — corresponding to 4-5 million tonnes of hot metal — could potentially be modified to adopt the EASyMelt approach. The attractiveness of the technology lies precisely in this possibility — reducing emissions from existing assets, rather than waiting for replacement with newer technologies.

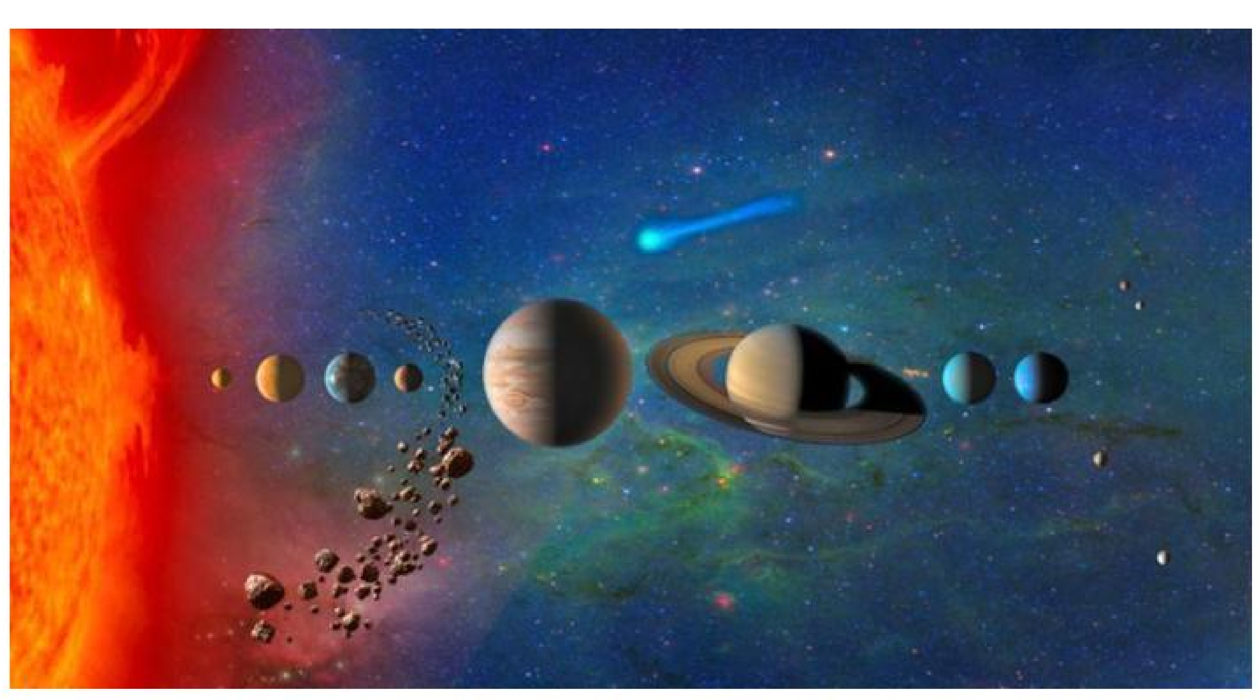
EASyMelt is Tata Steel's second low-carbon pathway to steel production. The company earlier worked on HIsarna (read 'The molten magic inside Tata Steel's HIsarna bet' in *businessline* dated April 20, 2026), an alternative iron-making route it developed in collaboration with European partners.

Unlike EASyMelt, which modifies an existing blast furnace, HIsarna seeks to replace the conventional blast furnace-coke oven route altogether. It combines ore preparation and iron reduction in a cyclone converter furnace, eliminating the need for coke ovens and sinter plants and producing a concentrated carbon dioxide stream, which could potentially be captured and stored.

The writer visited the Tata Steel factory in Jamshedpur at the invitation of the company

We value your feedback.
Do send your comments to
quantum@thehindu.co.in

◉ WOW. Wake up and smell the cosmos



Team Quantum

Rip Van Winkle slept for 20 years and woke up to find a changed world in the Washington Irving story. NASA's New Horizons spacecraft 'slept' for only 321 days, but its awakening was equally dramatic and scientifically significant.

On June 23, mission controllers of New Horizons, now 9.5 billion km from Earth, 'woke up' the spacecraft from the hibernation mode they had placed it in to conserve energy as it cruised along the edges of the solar system. They cheered on discovering all was well with the spacecraft.

Even while 'asleep', New Horizons was not idle. Its scientific senses were awake; its instruments continued collecting data on the outer region of the solar system, including solar wind, energetic particles and tiny dust particles.

Now awake, New Horizons will send stored data back to Earth and begin new observations of the distant heliosphere — the vast bubble around the solar system created by the Sun's influence. Far ahead of the heliosphere lies the heliopause, the invisible boundary where the Sun's influence fades away and interstellar space begins. New Horizons is meant to probe the heliopause.

Launched in 2006, it made history as the first spacecraft to fly past Pluto in 2015, and later explored Arrokoth, a distant object in the Kuiper belt. It continues its lonely journey through the outer reaches of the solar system, where few human-made machines have ever ventured.

Only the twin Voyager probes, launched in 1977, have gone farther than New Horizons while still being functional.

◉ BEYOND LI-ION

Reworking sulphur to win the energy storage race

K Bharat Kumar

Lithium-sulphur (Li-S) batteries have the potential to rule the roost in the next generation of energy storage technology. They come with five times higher energy density than standard lithium-ion batteries, higher capacity (1,675 mAh) and lower raw material cost.

But widespread adoption faces two stumbling blocks — leakage and sluggish reaction.

As the battery functions, the sulphur turns into temporary chemical forms that dissolve into the battery's liquid. Once dissolved, these molecules freely float back and forth between the positive and negative ends of the battery.

Each time these molecules float away, the battery loses the key materials it needs to store power. This causes the battery to drain rapidly and permanently lose its ability to hold a charge.

Second, charging and discharging the battery requires sulphur to constantly change its chemical state. Sulphur in the mix causes a solid build-up at the end of the discharge phase and this assumes insulation properties. Because electricity cannot pass through this layer easily, chemical reactions stall. Very slow charge is a common consequence of this build-up.

To prevent the build-up of solids containing sulphur, scientists have toyed with catalysts. Earlier, single metal atoms embedded in graphene (carbon) sheets were used to trap the leaking sulphur.

In a study published earlier this year in the *Small Journal*, researchers Sahil Kumar, et al found a more effective catalyst that used dual atoms.

Dual-atom catalysts (DACs), containing two different metal atoms side-by-side, act like a chemical magnet for the leaking sulphur. They also help split the tough sulphur bonds, allowing the battery to charge and discharge much faster.

ROLE OF AI

Now there are scores of metals and an even greater number of pairings possible.

How do you choose a pair? Trial-and-error method would take ages. The researchers instead used artificial intelligence to build a screening tool they named Precise and Accelerated Configuration Evaluation (PACE). This machine-learning workflow virtually tested 46,400 different structural arrangements in a short time. It filtered out the poorer options and helped select the optimal metal pairings.

The AI and the follow-up tests showed that the strength of the metal pair mattered a lot in the most suited one.

There are three types of pairs that deal with sulphur — metals like iron paired with titanium grip the sulphur so hard that they warp the catalyst and halt the reaction; some pairs were barely able to hold the sulphur at all.

BEST PAIRING

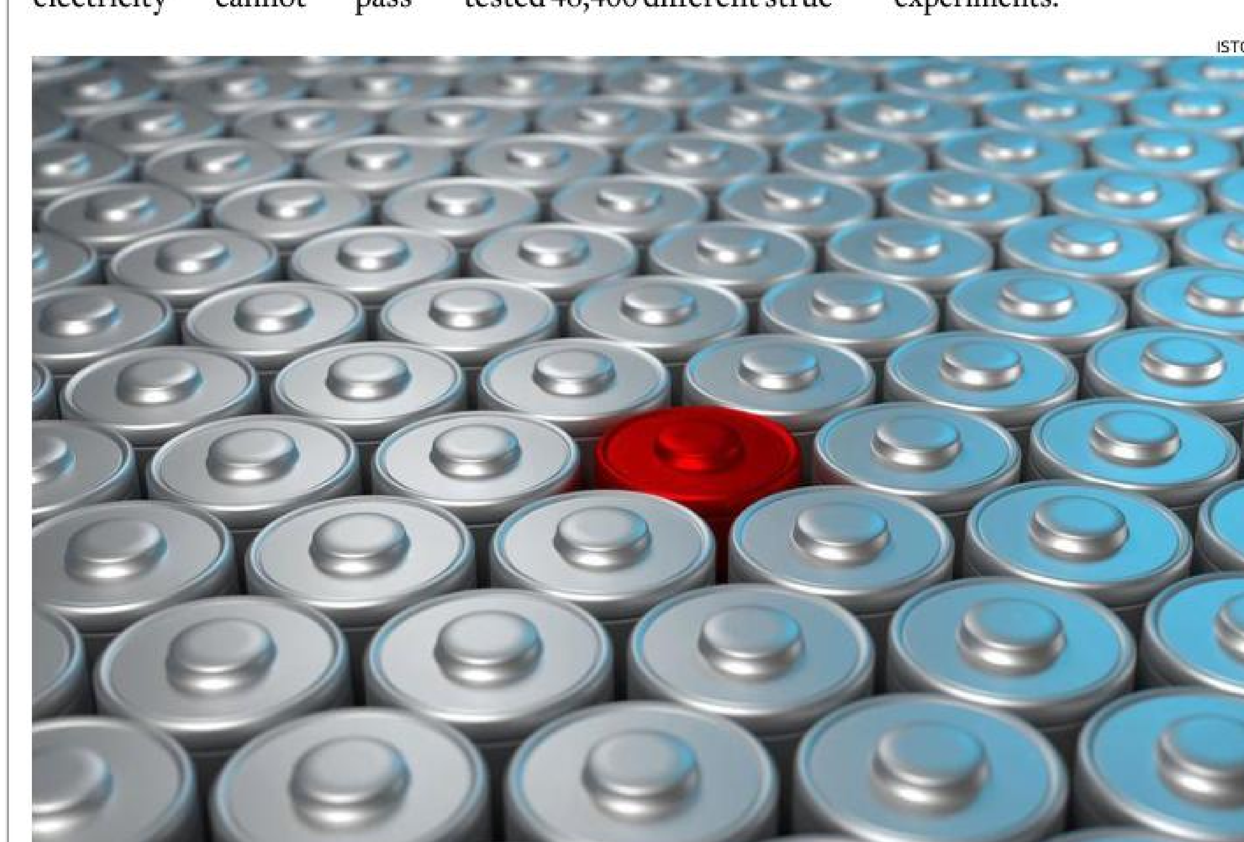
The combination of iron and nickel proved the most optimal.

And why was that?

This pair holds the sulphur tightly enough to halt the leaks but loose enough to allow the completion of the chemical reaction. This pair also used less than half the energy traditionally needed to break down battery waste during charging, and hence sped up the process.

The researchers used their data to train a predictive machine learning model. Now, if new researchers were to try a brand new metal pairing, they can type it into the model, and the computer will instantly predict how well it will perform without the need for new experiments.

ISTOCK



◉ ELEMENTARY SOLUTION

Tackling iron deficiency from a steel mill

How Tata Steel developed a nutritional supplement from a byproduct of galvanisation

M Ramesh

Anybody who has popped a pill for tackling iron deficiency may have thought, "Why not eat iron itself?" Research at Tata Steel's Iron Powder Development Centre has indeed made that possible.

Scientists at the centre are trying to give a surprising second life to a humble byproduct of steel making — iron powder.

The story begins with the galvanising process. When steel sheets are coated with zinc to protect them from corrosion, they undergo an acid-washing process. This generates iron-containing material, which when separated from the acid has typically found use in making red oxide pigment for paints.

Tata Steel is now trying to push this iron powder into more advanced applications. One of the most fascinating is a nutritional product: PIRONutri38, an elemental iron powder developed using Tata Steel's patented technology.

The idea sounds almost bizarre. Iron is something we associate with bridges, machinery and skyscrapers. The thought that the same element can be part of a nutritional supplement seems counter-intuitive.

But the human body requires iron to make haemoglobin, the protein in red blood cells that carries oxygen. Iron deficiency is one of the most common nutritional disorders globally, but it couldn't be addressed by swallowing a spoonful of iron powder. To be useful as a nutritional component, the iron must be available in a form that the body can access and absorb.

According to Tata Steel, PIRONutri38 has been developed as a high-bioavailability elemental iron powder. The bioavailability indicates how much iron becomes available for the human body under the conditions of the stomach.

The chemistry behind this is crucial. For iron to be useful nutritionally, it must first dissolve in the acidic environment of the stomach, so that it can become available for absorption.

ISTOCK

TASTE TEST

Tata Steel says PIRONutri38 shows 100 per cent solubility under simulated gastric conditions (pH 1 in dilute hydrochloric acid) within 30 minutes, indicating that the elemental iron is readily released in such an environment.

The company also says the powder has favourable sensory properties. In consumer evaluations, more than 80 per cent of respondents rated it above 7 on a scale of 1 to 9 for parameters including appearance, taste, aroma, colour, texture, flavour and overall palatability. The last point matters because nutrition products often fail not because the science is wrong, but because people do not like consuming them. Importantly, PIRONutri38 has been evaluated by a reputed national nutrition research institution for its suitability as an iron supplement ingredient.

However, Tata Steel is not getting into the business of making edible steel. It will license the technology to any food or nutrition company and stay content with the higher revenue from the sale of its iron powder.

A steel plant may appear to be an unlikely place for discovering a solution to iron deficiency. But perhaps, that is the point. In a world increasingly obsessed with circular economy, waste from one process could become raw material for another.

BENGALURU
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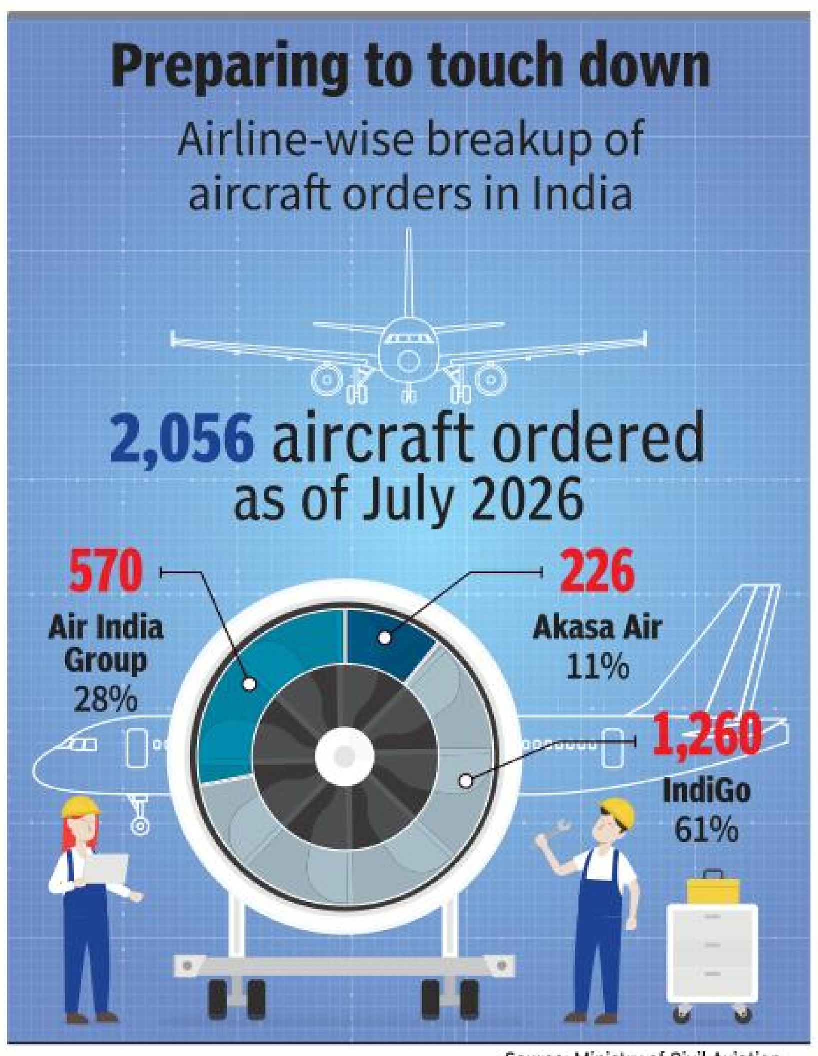


Source: Ministry of Civil Aviation

GLOBAL BYTES.

West Asia-Latin America aviation pact

Abra Group, a leading air transportation company across Latin America, and Etihad Airways have established a partnership to strengthen connectivity between Latin America, West Asia and key global markets. The MoU is a framework for long-term collaboration across Abra's airlines Avianca, GOL and Wamos Air, connecting Latin America, West Asia and the rest of Asia through complementary networks. The partnership includes immediate initiatives spanning network development, loyalty programmes, aircraft leasing and ACMI (aircraft, crew, maintenance and insurance) operations, according to a media release.

Counting carbon collectively

What was the carbon dioxide impact of your last flight? Unfortunately, the answer may depend on whom you ask. That is why IATA is advocating for a globally standardised approach to emissions reporting. IATA's CO2 Connect emissions calculator uses data from 110 airlines, which monitor and record every drop of fuel used by their aircraft. Unfortunately, Europe is moving in a direction that creates fragmentation, an unnecessary administrative burden and additional costs for airlines, says IATA. "Collaboration could pave the way for a standardised approach by regulators globally," said Michael Schneider, IATA's Assistant Director of Sustainability Programmes.

Multi-lane, free-flowing highways

Fee plazas for which contracts have been awarded for barrier-less tolling — vehicle users shall be charged without having to stop, slow down or stay in a given lane

Fee plaza	State	National highway
Choryasi	Gujarat	NH-48
Mundka	Delhi	UER-II
Daulatpura	Rajasthan	NH-48
Manoharpura	Rajasthan	NH-48
Shahjahanpur	Rajasthan	NH-48
Gharaunda	Haryana	NH-44
Nemili / Sriperumbudur	Tamil Nadu	NH-48
Chennasamudram	Tamil Nadu	NH-48
Paranur	Tamil Nadu	NH-45
Kasepalli	Andhra Pradesh	NH-44
Amakathadu	Andhra Pradesh	NH-44
Marur	Andhra Pradesh	NH-44
Chalakwadi	Maharashtra	NH-50
Hiwargaon Pawasa	Maharashtra	NH-50
Badarpur	Haryana	NH-19
Boriach	Gujarat	NH-48
Madanpur	Assam	NH-31

Source: Ministry of Road Transport & Highways

Truck rental rates

Rentals for 18-tonne payload

Truck route	Rentals as on		% change
	Jul 9	Jul 23	
Delhi-Mumbai-Delhi	1,76,000	1,75,000	-0.57
Delhi-Nagpur-Delhi	1,59,000	1,60,000	0.63
Delhi-Kolkata-Delhi	1,80,000	1,79,000	-0.56
Delhi-Guwahati-Delhi	1,96,000	1,97,000	0.51
Delhi-Hyderabad-Delhi	2,03,000	2,04,000	0.49
Delhi-Chennai-Delhi	2,19,000	2,20,000	0.45
Delhi-Bengaluru-Delhi	2,25,000	2,26,000	0.44
Delhi-Ranchi-Delhi	1,69,000	1,70,000	0.59
Delhi–Raipur-Delhi	1,66,000	1,65,000	-0.61
Delhi-Kandla-Delhi	1,45,000	1,44,000	-0.69
Mumbai-Chennai-Mumbai	1,75,000	1,73,000	-1.16
Ludhiana-Hyderabad-Ludhiana	2,04,000	2,01,000	-1.49
Mumbai-Kolkata-Mumbai	2,02,000	2,03,000	0.49
Chennai-Ahmedabad-Chennai	2,15,000	2,14,000	-0.47
Bengaluru-Kolkata-Bengaluru	2,16,000	2,15,000	-0.47
Bengaluru-Mumbai-Bengaluru	1,46,000	1,47,000	0.68
Delhi-Thiruvananthapuram-Delhi	2,84,000	2,85,000	0.35
Guwahati-Mumbai-Guwahati	2,86,000	2,85,000	-0.35
Nagpur-Chennai-Nagpur	1,66,000	1,67,000	0.60
Kolkata-Guwahati-Kolkata	1,58,000	1,60,000	1.25
Indore-Delhi-Indore	1,48,000	1,48,000	0.00
Ahmedabad-Indore-Ahmedabad	1,03,000	1,05,000	1.90
Vijayawada-Mumbai-Vijayawada	1,66,000	1,65,000	-0.61
Vijayawada-Kolkata-Vijayawada	1,57,000	1,56,000	-0.64
Mumbai-Nagpur-Mumbai	1,16,000	1,17,000	0.85
Mumbai-Pune-Mumbai	70,000	72,000	2.78
Mumbai-Aurangabad-Mumbai	86,000	85,000	-1.18
Mumbai-Nashik-Mumbai	69,000	70,000	1.43

Figures in ₹ — Source: Subham Freight Carriers India Pvt Ltd

CONTRASTING TAKE-OFFS

Greenfield airports: Diverging paths

PROGRESS REPORT. As Andhra Pradesh readies to add a new airport, why Tamil Nadu's effort is stuck at the starting block

T E Raja Simhan

With the greenfield Bhogapuram airport, near Visakhapatnam, set to be inaugurated on August 1 by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, comparisons have again surfaced between Andhra Pradesh's flagship aviation project and the proposed Parandur airport, near Chennai.

While both airports in southern India were conceived to meet the rising demand for aviation services, their timelines have diverged sharply because of the nature of the land identified for acquisition and the challenges that followed.

Bhogapuram, which has secured its aerodrome licence and is ready for commercial operations, received the site clearance from the Centre in 2016. The Andhra Pradesh government awarded the concession to GMR Airports in 2020, the foundation stone was laid in May 2023, and the construction was completed in about three years.

Parandur, in contrast, remains in the pre-construction stage despite the then Tamil Nadu government deciding on the site in 2022 and receiving the Centre's in-principle approval in 2023. The State is yet to complete land acquisition, appoint a developer or commence construction.

The new government, headed by Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam, is going slow on the project as its leader and Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay had supported the villagers of Parandur in opposing the greenfield project. This was also a stepping stone for his entry into politics.

HURDLES ON LAND

The Bhogapuram site largely comprises dry agricultural land, government land and scrubland with fewer habitations, making land acquisition primarily an exercise in compensation and rehabilitation.

At Parandur, on the other hand, at stake are nearly 5,000 acres of fertile irrigated farmland, wetlands and irrigation tanks spread across 13 villages. The project has faced sustained opposition from locals over the looming loss of multi-crop agricultural land, the disruption of irrigation systems and the ecological role of the interconnected wetlands that serve as flood buffers.

The complexity inherent in acquiring environmentally sensitive and densely cultivated land has slowed the project.

Officials familiar with both projects emphasised that it was like "comparing apples and oranges", given the vastly different land acquisition challenges. However, they acknowledged that the two projects continue to be viewed as benchmarks for infrastructure execution in southern India.

J Krishnan, partner at S Natesa Iyer Logistics LLP, said Andhra Pradesh's approach to site selection had helped it avoid controversies right from the early stage.

"The Andhra Pradesh government's initial search and identification of the airport land was methodical and the search committee eschewed any controversy likely to surface by interested groups. This ensured the project did not face major implementation delays," he said.

LOSS OF BUSINESS

Parandur has attracted environmental and livelihood concerns from day one, he pointed out. "The dense industrial and urban activity around Chennai has made identifying a new airport site particularly challenging. Differences are bound to surface even if alternative locations are identified," he added.

Industry stakeholders also stressed the economic implications of the delay.

Sharmindar Saravanan, Managing Director of SSK Smart Move Logistics Pvt Ltd, said Chennai's air cargo ecosystem is facing congestion, infrastructure limitations and lengthy processing times, prompting exporters and freight forwarders to consider routing cargo through Bengaluru, Hyderabad or Kochi.

"This is not merely a logistics issue — it is an economic competitiveness issue. If exporters continue shifting cargo to neighbouring States, Tamil Nadu risks losing business despite having one of India's largest manufacturing bases," he said.

He argued that Parandur is strategically important for the State's long-term industrial growth, investment attraction and export competitiveness.

Dinesh K Krishnan, Managing Director of United Shipping Services Pvt Ltd, said any major airport infrastructure should be viewed as a long-term strategic asset insulated from political changes.

"The trade community spent countless man-hours working alongside State agencies like TIDCO to shape the Parandur project. Extensive socio-economic, environmental and technical studies were completed to secure key regulatory clearances. To see the project paused or shelved without even a review meeting with trade stakeholders is deeply disappointing," he said.

He cautioned that Chennai's rapid industrial expansion requires additional passenger and cargo capacity to avoid future saturation, adding that prolonged delays could strengthen competing aviation hubs in Karnataka and Andhra Pradesh.

The contrasting experiences of the two airport projects underscore the fact that regulatory approvals alone do not determine the pace of large infrastructure development. The ability to complete land acquisition, rehabilitation and developer selection remains the decisive factor in moving projects from planning to execution stage.

Bhogapuram demonstrates that once these milestones are achieved, a greenfield airport can be completed in about three years. But nearly four years after Parandur was identified as the preferred site, Chennai's second airport is nowhere near the finishing line.

READY FOR BUSINESS. Bhogapuram international airport, near Visakhapatnam KR DEEPAK

Bhogapuram and Parandur airport projects: A timeline

Airport project	Bhogapuram (Andhra Pradesh)	Parandur (Tamil Nadu)
Site selection	2015-16	2022
Centre's in-principle approval	2016	2023
Land acquisition	Completed; predominantly dry agricultural and government land with limited displacement	Ongoing, with sustained local opposition; nearly 4,970 acres of fertile farmland, wetlands and 13 villages
Developer selection	GMR Airports (appointed in 2020)	Yet to be decided
Financial closure	Achieved before construction	Pending
Foundation stone laying	May 2023	Awaited
Construction	May 2023-26	None
Current status	Inauguration on August 1	Land acquisition stage

We value your feedback.
Do send your comments to
bl.logistics@thehindu.co.in

REALISTIC PLANNING

Demand-led port expansion

B SWAMINATHAN

India's maritime sector has experienced remarkable growth in recent years as the country seeks to strengthen its role in global manufacturing, trade and logistics networks. Government initiatives such as Sagarmala and Maritime Amrit Kaal Vision (MAKV) 2047 aim to expand port capacity, improve multimodal connectivity, promote coastal shipping and reduce logistics costs. Major investments are being made in new berths, deeper draughts, mechanised cargo handling, freight corridors, logistics parks, inland transport and digital infrastructure to create an integrated maritime and logistics ecosystem.

However, infrastructure expansion alone cannot ensure sustainable development. Port capacity must be aligned with realistic cargo demand projections. Since port projects involve substantial capital investment and a long gestation period, inaccurate forecasting can result in significant operational and financial inefficiencies. Excess capacity leads to underutilised terminals and idle equipment, and poor returns on investment. As global trade patterns and domestic economic conditions continue to evolve, port planning is becoming increasingly complex.

OPERATIONAL EFFICIENCY

In port planning, the concept of 'highest efficient attainable throughput' (HEAT) refers to the maximum cargo volume a port can handle efficiently without causing significant congestion. As traffic nears this threshold, berth occupancy rises, vessel turnaround slows, storage yards become congested and cargo-handling equipment comes under pressure. Beyond this level, efficiency declines quickly, leading to higher logistics costs, supply chain disruptions and reduced competitiveness.

To sustain efficiency, ports require timely capacity augmentation, operational modernisation, improved hinterland connectivity and digital integration. While infrastructure expansion remains important, equal emphasis must be placed on optimising existing assets and improving operational performance.

India's major and non-major ports are already showing signs of capacity imbalance. As of March this year, the country's ports had a combined handling capacity of nearly 2,762 million tonnes, while actual cargo traffic was about 1,668 million tonnes, reflecting around 60 per cent utilisation. International port planning practices, including guidance from the United Nations Conference on Trade and Development, generally consider around 70 per cent utilisation as efficient, as this balances flexibility with congestion control.

Since the 1970s, the UNCTAD has encouraged ports to maximise operational efficiency and optimise existing infrastructure before undertaking largescale expansion. The MAKV 2047 envisages creating nearly 10,000 million tonnes of port handling capacity by 2047, whereas the projected cargo traffic, assuming annual growth of about 6 per cent, is estimated at only 5,630 million tonnes. This suggests that the planned capacity of around 8,000 million tonnes would adequately meet future demand, highlighting the need for demand-driven infrastructure planning.

Rising competition among ports on the eastern and western coastlines, particularly with the rapid expansion of private ports, has led to overlapping infrastructure development and dispersed cargo movement. Future port development should be guided by realistic demand forecasting, integrated logistics planning and continuous market assessment.

This approach will improve competitiveness, optimise investments, strengthen supply chain resilience and ensure the long-term financial sustainability of India's maritime sector.

The writer is a retired associate professor of the Indian Maritime University–Chennai Campus. Views are personal

OPTIMISING USAGE. Cargo handling capacity must balance flexibility with congestion control B JOTHI RAMALINGAM

MARITIME BOOST

Act II for new AP ports

BIGGER AIM. Machilipatnam port awaits expansion GN RAO

G Naga Sridhar

Andhra Pradesh's port economy is poised for a major transformation. Even as the first phase of work on three greenfield ports nears completion, the State government is laying the ground for the next growth wave by committing ₹1,638.52 crore to acquire 6,248.54 acres for phase-II expansion.

The government has given administrative nod for land acquisition for the Ramayapatnam, Mulapeta and Machilipatnam ports, following directions from Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu, said Investments and Infrastructure Minister BC Janardhan Reddy.

Of the total allocation, ₹851 crore has been earmarked for acquiring 2,924.45 acres for the second phase of Ramayapatnam port.

The government has sanctioned ₹440.52 crore for acquiring 1,903.39 acres for the expansion of Mulapeta port. The proposed works will also cover the acquisition of salt lands and the implementation of rehabilitation and resettlement measures at Mulapeta.

For the second phase of expansion at Machilipatnam port, the government has approved the acquisition of 1,420.70 acres at a cost of ₹347 crore.

The approvals are expected to accelerate the expansion of the greenfield ports and strengthen Andhra Pradesh's maritime infrastructure.

With three of the five greenfield ports under construction expected to become operational within six months, the State's maritime capacity is set to grow significantly.

Cargo-handling capacity is expected to increase by more than 50 per cent — from 195 million tonnes per annum (MTPA) to 286 MTPA, according to official data.

"With the commencement of phase II development of the upcoming ports, the next five years will witness a major leap in port-based logistics in the State," a senior government official said.

As part of its maritime growth strategy, the State aims to achieve an optimal port capacity utilisation of 75 per cent by 2030 and cut vessel turnaround time to under 15 hours, thereby improving operational efficiency and competitiveness.

The State government recently proposed a partnership with South Korean maritime equipment manufacturers to invest in the upcoming Dugarajapatnam shipbuilding cluster, which is jointly developed by the Andhra Pradesh Maritime Board (APMB) and the Visakhapatnam Port Authority.

MY FIVE.

MANISH GUPTA
Chairman and CEO, Indegene

No-call mornings, yoga, and unwinding with books and spies

1. No calls: My days start with chai, taking in the morning stillness and freshness — free from work, no emails or calls.

2. Walks: A 60-minute brisk walk or an hour of Iyengar yoga every morning is non-negotiable. The rigour of exercise fills me with energy for everything the day has in store. I follow this up with 10-15 minutes of meditation to clear thoughts and calm me down before work.

3. Learning: The infamous Bengaluru traffic means I spend a lot of time in the car to get to office every day! I fill this time productively — listening to podcasts, YouTube videos and audiobooks on various topics. It keeps me mentally agile — I draw connections between work, life and all the new things I learn, which ends up helping in the most unexpected situations!

4. Eat together: My family eats dinner together every day. Our weekend dinners often extend to an hour or two — with good food, laughter and a large dose and variety of vegetables in our meals.

5. Intrigue: I am a fan of action movies, thriller TV shows. I unwind by watching them — a break from the hustle of everyday life into the realm of the fascinating lives of secret agents and spies. Sometimes a good book quietens the mind.

CAPSULE.

Road crashes kill 1.16 million

Despite the addition of more than one billion motor vehicles to the world's roads, the global rate of road traffic deaths declined by 21 per cent between 2011 and 2025, according to new data released by the World Health Organization (WHO).

The world has experienced profound changes in road traffic during this time, with the emergence of new modes of transport and a sharp rise in motorcycle use. At the same time, road traffic crashes claimed 1.16 million lives in 2025, it added. Road traffic injuries remain the leading cause of death among children and youth aged 5–29.

The WHO data comes as global leaders adopt a new United Nations General Assembly progress declaration on road safety to boost global action to meet the Sustainable Development Goal (SDG) target of 50 per cent reduction in road deaths and serious injuries by 2030, compared with the levels in 2021.

"This progress shows that change is possible when countries invest in safe road systems," said WHO Director-General Dr Tedros Adhanom Ghebreyesus.

COMING UP.

Freeing up hepatitis care

World Hepatitis Day is observed on July 28 every year to raise awareness on viral hepatitis, an inflammation of the liver that causes severe liver disease and liver cancer. This year's theme, 'Hepatitis: Let's break it down', is a call to remove the barriers between people and the services that can save their lives, the World Health Organization said. The tools needed to eliminate viral hepatitis already exist, including vaccines and lifelong therapies. And yet, millions remain undiagnosed or unable to access care due to stigma, health system gaps and persistent inequalities.

GRIM REMINDER

RG Kar and after: Unfinished task of keeping hospitals safe

ELUSIVE CURE. Two years after a medic's gruesome murder, healthcare workers remain vulnerable

PT Jyothi Datta

ISTOCK

A recent video showing a political representative in an altercation with medical staff, including seemingly raising his hand on a female doctor, at a hospital in Dombivli, near Mumbai, sparked widespread outrage, especially among the country's medical fraternity.

The incident — barely two years after a young trainee doctor was allegedly raped and killed at the RG Kar Hospital in Kolkata — serves as a grim reminder of the violence doctors continue to face. The shocking crime pushed doctors to demand measures to make hospitals a safe zone, including deployment of security personnel and CCTVs, and a Central Act to safeguard medical staff against violence.

And yet, multiple incidents of assaults on doctors in the ensuing months, including one as recently as in June at a hospital in Rajasthan and in July at Dombivli, have shown that the needle has not moved much when it comes to ensuring the personal safety of doctors, nurses and other medical staff against a rising tide of violence from attendants of patients.

Vinita (name changed on request), a resident doctor at a government medical college hospital, says doctors face the ire of the people accompanying patients for reasons that may be beyond their control. For example, she says, at any point there may be two or three doctors at the hospital's emergency room, which is overloaded with about 50 people. When doctors prioritise those needing immediate attention, it attracts complaints from those who may have arrived earlier with minor injuries, she explains.

"At such times we are subjected to verbal abuse," she says, adding that they call the security guards for help.

FEMINISATION OF STAFF

Dr RV Asokan, former President of the Indian Medical Association (IMA), points out that the profession is "feminising" — about 60 per cent of the doctors in the country are women. Hospitals need to become sensitive and safe workplaces for them, he says, adding that nothing really has changed on the ground.

Often doctors are blamed for administrative shortcomings, such as the absence of a specific facility needed to treat a particular condition, he says.

In the Dombivli Shastrinagar Municipal Hospital case, for instance, reports indicate that a pregnant lady had been advised to approach another government hospital for a neonatal ICU facility on a day Mumbai witnessed heavy rain. The corporator accused of the assault, whose bail has since been cancelled by the Bombay High Court, told mediapersons that he stepped into the picture to ensure the pregnant lady got the necessary care. He denied attacking the female doctor, and sought to clarify that he was merely knocking the phone out of her hand.

Two of the doctors who bore the brunt of the attack have since resigned, fearing for their safety, according to media reports.

SAFE ZONES

Sometimes, even the act of communicating a difficult situation to a patient's family turns into a tense moment, says a female doctor, adding that it calls for handling the situation with sensitivity, empathy and calm nerves.

This is where clinical training matters, and it can come not from textbooks but from ward rounds, says Asokan. The more patients young doctors see, the better they become at handling difficult situations and communicating bad news to families, he says. "The art of medicine is learnt at the bedside," he says. The "inhuman" workload on resident doctors — over 100 hours at times — adds to their stress. This certainly can be regulated, he adds.

Indranil Deshmukh, National Secretary of the IMA Junior Doctors Network, reminds authorities about their commitment to making hospitals "safe zones". There are incidents of violence against healthcare practitioners every other day, he says, calling for a Central Act to provide uniform protection to medical staff across the country, fast-track courts and clear penalties for those attacking hospital staff and infrastructure.

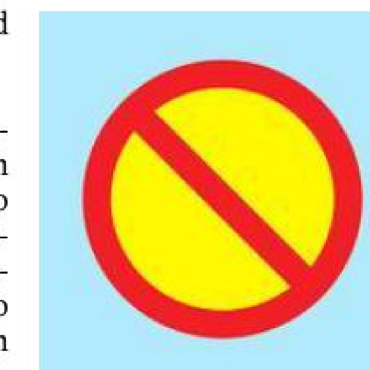
While hospitals in cities and metros may be able to install CCTVs for their protection, he says there is a need to also ensure a safe working environment for healthcare practitioners at primary health centres located in remote areas.

FROM THE REGULATOR

Australia says 'no' to nicotine pouches

New regulations are in place across Australia to restrict access to nicotine pouches to protect public health, said the country's Therapeutic Goods Administration. The changes follow consultations with stakeholders and reflect concerns over the health risks associated with emerging nicotine products, particularly their potential appeal to young people and the increased risk of nicotine dependence. From July 24, people can no longer import nicotine pouches through the Personal Importation Scheme nor access them through the Special Access Scheme or Authorised Prescriber Scheme nor have them compounded by pharmacists.

The Personal Importation Scheme allowed individuals to import therapeutic goods for personal use under certain conditions. The Special Access Scheme and Authorised Prescriber Scheme enabled health practitioners to prescribe unapproved therapeutic goods to patients when the use is clinically justified.



ISTOCK

Pharmacists and certain other healthcare practitioners could compound medicines for individual patients when an approved medicine is not suitable. Under the new rule, nicotine pouches cannot be compounded for individual patient use.

Prof Anthony Lawler, Deputy Secretary of the Department of health, disability and ageing, and head of TGA, said, "These changes respond to growing public health concern about nicotine pouches and their increasing availability in the Australian market. They strengthen the ability of the TGA and its partner agencies to combat the unlawful importation, advertising and supply of nicotine pouches, while ensuring Australians have access to safe, approved and evidence-based options to quit smoking and manage nicotine dependence."

Nicotine is highly addictive, and its use during adolescence can affect brain development and increase the risk of ongoing dependence. There is limited evidence that nicotine pouches help people quit smoking or manage nicotine dependence, and their full health impacts remain unknown. They may pose significant health risks, including high or inconsistent nicotine content, potential contaminants and misleading labelling.

Australians have access to nicotine replacement therapies such as patches, gum and lozenges, as well as medicines where clinically appropriate.

Source: TGA

LENS ON HEALTH

RAGING WORRIES. Healthcare workers light a bonfire as they protest outside the Elikya Ebola Treatment Centre to demand payment of pending wage benefits after a visit by Prime Minister Judith Suminwa Tuluka, as authorities intensify efforts to contain the Ebola outbreak involving the Bundibugyo strain, in Bunia, Democratic Republic of Congo REUTERS

NFHS-6 flags regional shifts in healthcare needs

BY INVITATION

POONAM MUTTREJA

SKEWED BURDEN. Female sterilisation dominates family planning

On May 29, the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare released the much-awaited sixth round of the National Family Health Survey (NFHS-6). The 'national' data, in reality, tells the story of many regions that are increasingly diverging in ways that make governance under one policy framework untenable.

India's total fertility rate (TFR) stands at 2, below the replacement level of 2.1 and unchanged from the previous round of the survey about five years ago. But this story of stability seems inaccurate once you start reading past the national average.

Urban India's TFR is 1.6, while for rural India it is 2.1; Bihar continues to lead among states, with a TFR of 2.7. At the same time, states like Tamil Nadu, Karnataka and Kerala have been below replacement level for decades.

Some regions still require investment in reproductive health, contraception, girls' education and child marriage prevention. Others need to prepare for ageing populations, care systems, changing labour markets and low fertility. A one-size-fits-all population policy is out of date.

The same pattern recurs across reproductive health indicators. The national unmet need for family planning has declined marginally from 9.4 per cent in NFHS-5 to 8.5 per cent in NFHS-6. But this aggregate hides serious State-level gaps. Meghalaya records unmet need at 21 per cent, Bihar 14.4 per cent, Jharkhand 12.6 per cent and Uttar Pradesh 10.8 per cent. Behind these numbers are millions of women who want to delay or avoid pregnancy but are unable to use contraception.

The method mix also remains highly gendered. Female sterilisation continues to dominate contraception, while male sterilisation remains negligible at 0.5 per cent. Andhra Pradesh, for instance, has a female sterilisation rate of 69.5 per cent. This should force us to ask whether high contraceptive prevalence truly reflects choice or whether the burden of family planning continues to fall overwhelmingly on women.

NFHS-6 also reminds us that fertility cannot be separated from adolescent health and gender inequality. Child marriage has declined nationally, but 20.1 per cent of women aged 20–24 were married before 18. In West Bengal, Bihar and Tripura, more than one in three young women were married before adulthood. Adolescent motherhood remains virtually unchanged nationally at 6.7 per cent and is far higher in States such as Tripura, West Bengal, Jharkhand and Bihar.

The policy lesson from NFHS-6 is clear — India must move from national templates to geography-specific, lifecycle-based and women-centred health planning. High-fertility rural regions need improved reproductive health services, adolescent health programmes, contraception access and action against child marriage. Low-fertility and ageing regions need care infrastructure, active ageing and geriatric health services, childcare, women's workforce support and social protection.

Above all, India must place women's agency at the centre. Health policy cannot simply count births, contraceptive use or institutional deliveries. It must ask whether women have the power to make informed decisions about marriage, contraception, childbirth, healthcare and work.

NFHS-6 shows there is no single India. Our health policy must recognise that reality. The future lies not in population panic or national averages, but in local evidence, women's rights and health systems that respond to the lives people actually lead.

The writer is Executive Director, Population Foundation of India. Views are personal

PMOS: A name change that validates women's concerns

Those coping with the symptoms need to be assured it's a complex metabolic-hormonal condition deserving attention

DAMINI GROVER

ISTOCK

Women with polycystic ovary syndrome (PCOS) have heard the same things for years: "Just lose weight", "handle your stress" or "take the pill".

PCOS is now a recognised condition, yet many women continue to suffer in silence, not just physically but also emotionally and psychologically.

Following the renaming of PCOS to poly metabolic ovary syndrome (PMOS), there was debate over the need for the name change. I believe this conversation is far more important than people realise, even from a mental health perspective.

The usage PCOS often reduces the condition to an ovarian, reproductive issue. But for many women, it is about so much more than irregular periods or cysts. It affects mood, energy, self-worth, body image, stress response, eating patterns, sleep and sometimes even a woman's sense of self and trust in her own body — issues we see in therapy rooms every day.

The PMOS terminology recognises what women have been dealing with for years — this condition is metabolic, hormonal, inflammatory and systemic, not just ovarian. And that shift in understanding is definitely psychologically validating as well.

In my experience as a woman living with PCOS and a therapist, I see women carrying layers of emotional exhaustion that are repeatedly minimised while coping with chronic fatigue, brain fog, weight changes, bloating, mood fluctuations, sleep disruption, hair loss, acne, anxiety, food cravings and body image concerns. Many don't even know that these experiences may be related. Instead, they internalise them as "I am lazy", "I'm not disciplined", "Why can't I move my body?", "Why am I so emotional?" or "Why is everyone else coping better than me?"

This is where mental health and hormonal health become deeply intertwined, and most people don't know about it. When a woman's body is unpredictable, exhausted, inflamed or constantly "off", it takes a psychological toll. Research consistently shows that women with PCOS have higher rates of anxiety, depression, eating disorders and body image distress. Many describe it as a constant battle with their own bodies and yet they continue to work, care for others and appear socially while silently battling symptoms that others cannot see. They are often told, "You looked fine yesterday", "You think too much", "Everyone gets tired" or "You just need more motivation".

What is overlooked is that persistent hormonal and metabolic dysregulation affects not only the body but also emotional regulation, stress tolerance, concentration, motivation and mood.

Perhaps the PMOS conversation is psychologically helpful because it expands the story. It tells women this isn't "just periods", "just weight" or a personal failure. It is a complex metabolic-hormonal condition that deserves attention. Simply understanding that "I'm not imagining my exhaustion", "My mood swings are not me being dramatic" or "My body is not betraying me on purpose" can reduce shame and make healing more compassionate.

Most importantly, the conversation needs to move away from appearance-based narratives. Many women with PCOS are not just dealing with symptoms but also self-criticism every day. This is why language matters. A better understanding of conditions like PMOS can support mental health, not because a name changes reality but because being understood certainly can.

The writer is the founder of I'M Powered centre for counselling and well-being

BENGALURU
businessline.
MONDAY - JULY 27 - 2026

QUICKLY.

Iran to halt attacks if US maintains pause

Dubai/Washington: Iran will halt its own attacks as long as the US maintains its latest pause on air strikes, a senior Iranian official told *Reuters* on Sunday, after US President Donald Trump abruptly called off his 13 nights of intensifying air strikes on Iran late on Friday to allow more time for diplomatic discussions. No US attacks were reported on Saturday or Sunday as well. Iran, which had been following each night of US attacks with its own strikes on neighbouring countries that host US bases, has also so far held fire for two days. The US ambassador to the United Nations, Mike Waltz, told *Fox News* on Sunday that Trump had decided to pause US attacks to allow more time for diplomacy. "He's giving talks some space, he's giving it a little bit of room," said Waltz, without providing further details. REUTERS

Nilekani to head task force on NTA reforms: PM

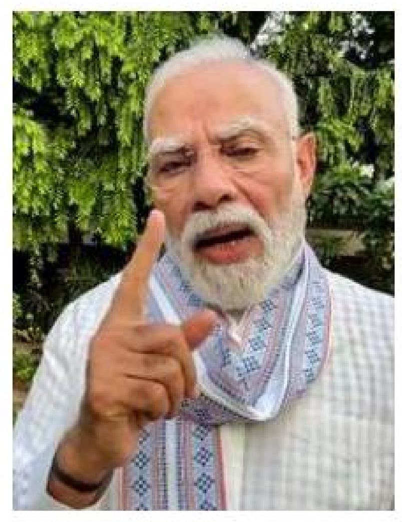
EXAM SCRUTINY. Announcement comes amid scrutiny of agency following a series of controversies over competitive examinations in recent years

Ankita Upadhyay
New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday announced the constitution of a high-power task force headed by technology expert Nandan Nilekani to recommend reforms for the National Testing Agency (NTA), with a focus on overhauling the examination system through technology and structural changes.

The announcement comes amid sustained scrutiny of the NTA following a series of controversies over competitive examinations in recent years.

In a message on social media platform X, the PM said: "Friends, for the future of the students, the Indian government is taking many steps continuously. The people who played with the future of the students, they are rotting in the jails. We have already made a fast track court. Even in the Parliament tomorrow, we are moving forward with the implementation of new laws. But we have to think about the future. We have to make sure that our exam procedures are safe. We have to make sure that our exam procedures are transparent. We have to make sure that most of the technology is used in our exam procedures. With all these things in mind, under the leadership of the world-famous technology expert Nandan Nilekani, we have decided to form a high-power task force which will focus on examination reform. And soon, the task of ensuring the reliability of upcoming exams will be done on the basis of the report of the task force," he added.


PM Narendra Modi

According to the details shared by the government, the multidisciplinary panel will recommend reforms to revamp the NTA's examination processes, particularly from a technology perspective, while also suggesting structural changes to strengthen the integrity and efficiency of the testing system.

TASK FORCE
- **Nandan Nilekani,** architect of Aadhaar
- **S Somanath,** former ISRO Chairman
- **Tapan Deka,** former Intelligence Bureau Director
- **V Kamakoti,** IIT (Madras) Director
- **Anita Karwal,** former Education Secretary
- **Amrit Lal Meena,** logistics expert

The task force will be chaired by Nandan Nilekani, Co-founder of Infosys and the architect of Aadhaar. It will include former Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO) Chairman S Somanath, former Intelligence Bureau Director Tapan Deka, Indian Institute of Technology-Madras Director V Kamakoti, former Education Secretary Anita Karwal and logistics expert and former civil servant Amrit Lal Meena.

The inclusion of experts from technology, education, intelligence, space research and logistics signals the government's attempt to address multiple aspects of examination management, including digital infrastructure, cybersecurity, operational planning and governance.

The announcement follows months of debate over the credibility of national entrance examinations conducted by the NTA.

Allegations of paper leaks, irregularities and technical glitches in examinations such as NEET-UG triggered nationwide protests and legal challenges, prompting the Centre to promise a comprehensive overhaul.

INSTITUTIONAL REFORMS

The newly constituted panel is expected to examine ways to improve the security, transparency and robustness of examinations through technological interventions while recommending institutional reforms for the NTA.

Meanwhile, Union Minister Pralhad Joshi on Sunday assumed additional charge of the Ministry of Education and said that he had begun reviewing the Ministry's functioning by holding detailed meetings with senior officials.

Speaking to reporters after taking charge, Joshi said that he was familiarising himself with the Ministry's work before making any decisions. "I have taken charge of the Ministry. I am learning about the Ministry and the decisions I have to take as the Minister. I am getting to understand the Ministry from 11 am till 3 pm in the evening. I also spoke with the officials in detail. This is a big department. I will speak in detail after understanding its functioning," he said.

Later in the day, Joshi chaired a review meeting of the Ministry, where he took stock of the implementation of various schemes and ongoing initiatives.

Minister of State for Education Jayant Chaudhary also attended the meeting.

Secretary, Department of Higher Education, Vineet Joshi, and Secretary, Department of School Education and Literacy, TK Anil Kumar, along with senior officers of the Ministry, were present at the review meeting.

India-US trade talks likely to gather pace only after Section 301 excess capacity investigations

Amiti Sen
New Delhi

India-US bilateral trade agreement (BTA) negotiations are unlikely to see meaningful progress until the US concludes its pending Section 301 investigations into alleged structural excess capacity even though Washington has already announced the outcome of its separate forced labour probe, sources said.

The outcome of the excess capacity investigations is expected to have a greater bearing on the contours of the trade agreement as it could result in additional trade measures, including higher tariffs, on a wide range of products such as steel, automobiles, textiles, medical devices, solar panels and petrochemicals, shaping the overall negotiating environment between the two countries.

"The forced labour investigation has provided some clarity on the emerging US trade regime, but it is only one part of the larger Section 301 exercise. The excess capacity investigations are likely to have much broader implications for trade flows and market access. Meaningful movement in the BTA is expected only after those findings are out," a source tracking the matter told *businessline*.

BIGGER CONCERN

Last week, the US announced an additional 10 per cent tariff on imports from India under its new Section 301 forced labour regime.

The additional forced labour tariffs would be imposed on about 55 per cent of India's exports as an estimated 45 per cent of exports fall under various exempted categories, according to the Indian government's calculations.

The bigger concern, however, is that India and 15 other countries are awaiting the outcome of the investigations into alleged excess capacities in several sectors, as the findings could result in further trade actions or tariffs affecting a broader range of imports. Others being investigated include China, the EU, Singapore, Switzerland, Norway, Indonesia, Malaysia, Cambodia, Thailand, Korea, Vietnam, Taiwan, Bangladesh, Mexico and Japan.

EXCESS CAPACITY

"Unless the Section 301 tariffs on excess capacity are decided, there can be no further progress on India-US BTA. Let's wait for final decision on 301 excess capacity tariffs," pointed out Pankaj Chadha, Chairman, EEPC India. Engineering goods, including steel and automobile products, are among the target products in the excess capacity investigations.

As per the USTR notification on the Section 301 excess capacity investigations, "India's global goods trade surplus sectors include textiles, health, construction goods and automotive goods. For example, evidence suggests the solar module sector is plagued by excess capacity, including that India's current module manufacturing is nearly triple the annual domestic demand. India also has created significant excess capacity in petrochemicals, steel and other industries."

Retailers wary as memory prices push smartphones out of customer's reach

Vallari Sanzgiri
Mumbai

Rising memory costs and wary consumer trends in the first half of 2026 have sparked fears of a muted festival season in 2026 as half of the retailers in a recent market survey anticipate a decline in sales.

While higher per-phone prices are holding up rupee turnover, retailers worry about survival by December 2026.

Following reports of cautious purchases by customers in the face of rising memory costs, the All India Mobile Retailers Association (AIMRA) and Techarc market research found that 49 per cent of the 1,126 retailers interviewed had already reported a business decline in the first six months of the calendar year. 61 per cent retailers said they sold fewer smartphone units between January and June 2026 than during the same period in 2025.

Conversations with retailers in Mumbai revealed that while the footfall of smartphone customers remains unchanged, the enthusiasm to buy the devices has lessened compared to last year. This trend is common across both small and large retailers.

"Memory costs have pushed up smartphone prices but customers do not want to move beyond their budget range. Some look for discounts or alternative options, while others leave without making a purchase," said a Vijay Sales employee in Thane, speaking on the condition of anonymity.

Another local retailer added that customers were walking out of the shop without making a purchase. When asked about festive season expectations, both retailers adopted a wait-and-watch approach.

"This report confirms what many of us have felt at the counter through the first half of 2026: Rising memory and component costs are pushing phone prices beyond what our customers can afford, and it is volume — the number of handsets we sell — that is quietly bearing the brunt, even where rupee turnover appears steady," said Kailash Lakhyani, Founding Chairman, All India Mobile Retailers Association (AIMRA), in the *Retailer Pulse* report.

Overall, 50 per cent of retailers worry about festive season sales.

Also, 48 per cent of retailers are worried that their business will not survive until the end of 2026. This is concerning given that retailers are expected to be the final influence on purchase decisions amidst current price uncertainties, as per Counterpoint Research.

CHANGING LEVERS

While smartphone sales declined in terms of volume, purchase value held ground with 43.7 per cent reporting higher value, as per the *Retailer Pulse* report.

In response to this trend, brands are now realigning their portfolio towards higher-value products rather than entry-level phones, industry sources told *businessline*.

This means that the worst of the sales decline will be borne by retailers operating in the base-to-mid price smartphone segment. Already, 81 per cent of retailers expect the ₹10,000–30,000 mass market to bear the most pressure in H2, according to the report. The sub-₹1 crore and single independent outlets show the highest survival risk and the least value cushion.

Chains and larger stores are weathering the situation better, largely due to the growing dependence on smartphones, as per Counterpoint Research.

"Consumers' dependence on smartphones has grown significantly, leading to a clearer understanding of the features and experiences they value. Against this backdrop, price increases are driving shifts in consumer purchase plans, creating opportunities for brands with strong pull, especially in the mid-to-premium segment. Brands offering a balanced portfolio across adjacent price bands are likely to benefit from this movement," said Arushi Chawla, Senior Analyst, Counterpoint Research, in its recent report.

The research firm reported that 54 per cent of smartphone buyers refused to stretch their budget for smartphone purchases, with 25 per cent of consumers opting to delay their purchases. The remaining 29 per cent consumers looked for alternative solutions like refurbished devices within the planned budget.

While Counterpoint Research stressed that the largest cohort of 46 per cent of consumers are willing to stretch their budget within the next six months for preferred smartphones, a combined reading with the retailer report and the counterpoint findings show that the willingness has failed to translate into actual purchases so far.

Faced with the possibility of a muted festive season, 53 per cent of the retailers have asked that the government reduce the GST on smartphones as well as the import duty.

CBDT issues detailed crypto reporting norms, tightening tax oversight without changing levy

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

The Central Board of Direct Taxes (CBDT) has issued a comprehensive guidance note, laying down reporting obligations for crypto exchanges and other intermediaries, marking a significant step towards bringing virtual digital asset (VDA) transactions under a more structured tax reporting framework.

The move comes shortly after the Parliamentary Standing Committee on Finance urged the government to examine the need for a statutory and regulatory framework for VDAs.

"The note describes the scope of the crypto assets and intermediaries that are covered, the basis on which a service provider is required to report, the identification of reportable persons, the due diligence procedures to be followed and the requirements and procedure for furnishing the report," said Prasenjit Singh, Member, CBDT, in the introductory note of the 198-page document.

Cryptos in India are neither legal nor illegal, though its transaction attracts tax deducted at source (TDS) and profits attract 30 per cent interest tax under the mechanism of taxation on VDA, which also includes NFT and similar products but not CBDCs.

While the responsibility of TDS lies with crypto exchanges and intermediaries that facilitate the transaction, profit must be reported by the recipient. There is no change in this entire structure, but the reporting has been further streamlined.

A STRUCTURAL SHIFT

According to Punit Agarwal, Founder and CEO of KoinX, for the industry, this is a structural shift. Crypto platforms must evolve from being purely transaction infrastructure to becoming compliance infrastructure, with robust systems for tax residency determination, customer due diligence, transaction classification and standardised reporting.

"This will accelerate investment in RegTech and tax technology, and platforms that invest early in strong tax reporting and compliance capabilities will be best positioned as more jurisdictions begin exchanging crypto tax information," he said, while adding that for investors the message is equally clear.

"While CARF doesn't impose any new taxes, it significantly raises the global standard for transparency," he said.

Experts said the guidelines can be summed up in four broad aspects. First, it aims for greater transparency. This will be possible as crypto transactions will increasingly come within the ambit of structured reporting and information exchange like the existing FATCA and common reporting standard framework. The second is better visibility for tax authorities. The objective is to bridge the information gap that existed because crypto assets could be transferred or held outside the traditional financial system. The third is global alignment. India is aligning its reporting standards with internationally accepted OECD norms, thereby strengthening cross-border exchange of crypto transaction information. And fourth, there is no change in taxability.

The note is procedural in nature and should not be interpreted as introducing a new tax or altering the existing taxation framework.

Vanishing spirit: Why has Old Monk rum gone missing from liquor shelves across Maharashtra?

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

Rajesh Chhabria, 35, a Nagpur banker, enjoys Glenfiddich and Singleton single malts. But when the monsoon arrives, he reaches for Old Monk.

At a recent get-together, friends braved the rain to join him for hot kebabs, onion pakoras and India's best-known dark rum. But his home bar had no Old Monk to offer. He went looking for a bottle, but shops across Nagpur had no stock or said supplies were irregular. Local bars offered Old Monk by the peg but refused takeaway bottles.

> **Delays in bottling or dispatches can leave one market** short without affecting another

SEASONAL DEMAND

Chhabria called tipplers in Pune, Akola and Mumbai but the answer was the same: supplies of the smiling monk on the label, affectionately known as the 'Budha Sadhu', have become irregular across Maharashtra.

What began as one consumer's search for his favourite monsoon drink is emerging as a wider supply squeeze.

Retailers and distributors say Old Monk has become increasingly difficult to replenish just as seasonal demand accelerates, raising questions over whether ethanol diversion, bottling constraints or distribution bottlenecks are disrupting supplies of one of India's most enduring liquor brands.

IS ETHANOL TO BLAME ?

That question is now echoing through liquor stores and distribution warehouses across Maharashtra.

Industry executives say ethanol diversion alone does not explain the shortage.

While the Centre's ethanol-blending programme has increased demand for molasses-based feedstock, the current crunch appears to reflect a perfect storm, a predictable monsoon demand surge colliding with bottling and dispatch constraints at facilities serving western India, including the Khopoli unit, along with State excise approvals, transport permits and distributor allocations.

Because alcohol is regulated State by State, delays in bottling or dispatches can leave one market short without affecting another.

If monsoon were the primary reason, trade executives argue, competing dark rum brands would also be disappearing from the shelves.

Instead, the shortage appears largely confined to Old Monk, pointing to a brand-specific supply-chain issue, rather than an industry-wide shortage of rum.

TCPL pinning growth on new-age portfolio as tea and salt business remains steady, says CEO

Aishwarya Kumar
Bengaluru

Tata Consumer Products Ltd (TCPL) is increasingly leaning on its fast-growing portfolio of newer businesses to power its next phase of growth, as its legacy tea and salt categories settle into a mature growth trajectory.

The company said businesses such as Tata Sampann, Capital Foods, Organic India and ready-to-drink (RTD) beverages will continue to underpin double-digit revenue growth, with the management maintaining that these segments can sustain 25-30 per cent growth going forward.

Speaking during the company's post-quarter analyst call, Sunil D'Souza, Managing Director and CEO, said growth businesses now account for 36 per cent of the India business after expanding 47 per cent year-on-year.


Sunil D'Souza, Managing Director and CEO, Tata Consumer Products Ltd

"Our aspirations are at 25 to 30 per cent growth... 25 to 30 per cent should be the new normal going forward," he said, adding that the company will continue investing in innovation, advertising and distribution to scale these businesses.

While reaffirming the company's long-term outlook, D'Souza said TCPL expects to continue delivering double-digit overall revenue growth despite a high base.

"We will drive double-digit growth. There will be those odd quarters where we will have mid-teens. There will be those quarters where it will be low double-digits," he said, noting that the runway for the company's growth businesses remains "as long as you can imagine."

REVENUE RISES

The comments came after TCPL reported a 12 per cent year-on-year increase in consolidated revenue from operations to ₹5,349 crore for the June quarter, while net profit rose 29 per cent to ₹427 crore. India-branded business posted 13 per cent underlying volume growth, while the international business grew 16 per cent on a reported basis.

D'Souza said the beverages business faced temporary headwinds during the quarter. "A minor issue of LPG shortages impacting small restaurants and street-side vendors, including tea shops in the South, did impact the business," he said.

Overseas, an unusually warm June affected demand across key markets. "The US, the UK and Canada were impacted, especially in the month of June, by the unusually warm summer... Most specifically in the UK and in the black tea category," he noted. However, coffee continued to perform strongly, growing 24 per cent, while the salt business delivered a robust performance despite calibrated price hikes taken during June.